

CJI-LED BENCH ASKS CENTRE, STATES TO RESPOND, DIRECTS PRESERVATION OF FOOTAGE

Petitions flag police ‘excesses’, SC weighs independent probe option

Orders release of detained minors, no coercive action against students

Ananthkrishnan G
New Delhi, July 28

UNDERLINING THE need to fix accountability, the Supreme Court Tuesday considered setting up a Special Investigation Team for a “completely independent, transparent, fair probe” into allegations of police excesses on those protesting against exam paper leaks in Delhi and other states.

Ordering the release of “children under the age of 18, who have been reported to be arrested or detained in connection with the ongoing protests and who do not possess any criminal antecedents”, the bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, Justice Joymalya Bagchi and Justice V Mohana said, “The NCT of Delhi and other States may proceed with the investigation of the FIRs registered; however, no coercive measures shall be taken against the protesting students. Such protection, nonetheless, shall not be extended to the persons with criminal antecedents.”

The bench said it would take a call on an independent probe after examining the responses of the Centre and states. As an interim measure, it directed that CCTV, drone and body cam footage, wireless communication and PCR notes related to the protest be preserved.

The petitioners have demanded that the probe committee should be headed by a former Chief Justice of India.

The bench, however, said “prior to issuing any such order based on a tentative opinion, we consider it appropriate, in the interest of justice, to afford a brief period to the NCT of Delhi and the Union of India to submit their respective versions through an affidavit accompanied by relevant material. Likewise, we find it necessary to grant a short hearing to the various States where similar acts of

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PM Narendra Modi with Union Ministers Rajnath Singh, Amit Shah and J P Nadda at the NDA Parliamentary Party meeting, Tuesday. PTI

PM video briefly blocked, Meta’s global officials get summons from Centre

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, July 28

THE MINISTRY of Electronics and IT (MeitY) has summoned Meta’s global policy heads after a video posted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi last week, in which he had promised strict measures against paper leaks, was briefly withheld by Facebook in India, sources said.

The ministry also intends to discuss Meta’s compliance with India’s technology-focussed laws, and deepfakes on its various social media platforms.

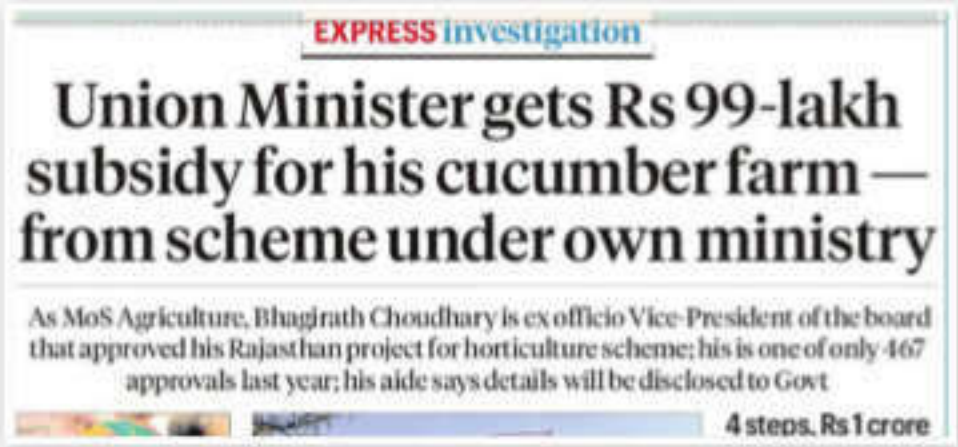
The summons are understood to have been sent via email to Meta’s global affairs president, Joel Kaplan, and Instagram’s chief, Adam Mosseri.

A Meta spokesperson said the PM’s video was removed “in error” and has since been restored. Queries sent to the IT Ministry did not elicit any response.

“We have been having various meetings with Meta’s

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Agriculture MoS returns Rs 99-lakh subsidy availed from own ministry scheme



The Indian Express report published on June 27

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, July 28

A MONTH after *The Indian Express* reported that Union MoS for Agriculture Bhagirath Choudhary had availed a Rs 99-lakh subsidy for his cucumber farm through a scheme under his own ministry, the Government told Lok Sabha on Tuesday that the Minister has refunded the amount.

In a written reply to a question by TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee, Ramnath Thakur, who is also an MoS in the Ministry, said, “Shri Bhagirath Choudhary has communicated that he has refunded the subsidy to the bank concerned under the scheme. The concerned bank has been directed to return the subsidy amount to NHB (National Horticulture Board).”

Thakur also informed the House that apart from Bhagi-

rath Choudhary, Lumbaram Choudhary, BJP MP from Jalore in Rajasthan, had also received financial assistance under the NHB scheme during the past five years.

The Indian Express reported on June 27 that Bhagirath Choudhary’s farm, spread across 16,592 square metres, was one of the 467 projects approved by the NHB in 2025 under the scheme, “Development of Commercial Horticulture through Production and Post-Harvest Management of Horticulture Crops”.

The NHB, an autonomous organisation under the administrative control of Choudhary’s Ministry, administers the subsidy scheme to promote “commercial farming” — farming on a large scale for profit — of select vegetables and flowers under Mission for Integrated

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INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 29~07~2026

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All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer

writing of other topics in the main exam.

2022 Khargone communal violence: 11 accused acquitted by court as prosecution case collapses

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, July 28

A MADHYA Pradesh sessions court has acquitted 11 men accused in the 2022 Khargone Ram Navami violence after the prosecution’s case collapsed with eight of its 11 eyewitnesses failing to identify any of the accused and laboratory findings failing to establish the alleged use of petrol bombs or any explosive substance.

The case arose from the com-



At least 16 houses and 29 shops were demolished in Khargone, MP, a day after the Ram Navami violence on April 10, 2022. FILE

munal violence that erupted in Khargone on April 10, 2022 during Ram Navami processions.

According to the prosecution, mobs armed with stones, swords and petrol bombs attacked houses in the Bhatwadi locality between 6 pm and 9 pm, setting homes and motorcycles on fire, damaging property and allegedly trespassing into residences. One man, identified as Idris Khan, was killed in the violence.

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• SHARMILA DHANKAR WINS INDIA'S FIRST-EVER COMMONWEALTH GAMES GOLD MEDAL IN PARA ATHLETICS

CWG para gold at 40, her message to women tells a story: ‘Fight back against abuse’

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, July 28

SHARMILA DHANKAR still remembers the day in 2012 when her then husband stripped her and threw her and their two young daughters out of their home in Ghurkawas village of Rewari in Haryana. She says her neighbours wrapped her in a quilt before her parents, Jai Lal and Santosh, took her back to their village of Chithhraul in Mahendragarh.

For Sharmila, that was the lowest of lows.

On Monday night in Glasgow, the 40-year-old won India’s first-ever Commonwealth

Games gold medal in para athletics — a season-best throw of 9.81m in the women’s shot put F57 category for athletes with lower-limb impairment.

Soon after, she called her mother, daughters and Ajit Singh, whom she married in 2018, to celebrate the high.

“My first husband stripped me. My neighbours wrapped

me in a quilt. I was married at 19, he was a drug addict, and things (the abuse) got worse after my second daughter was born. As I hold this gold medal in Glasgow, my message to every woman in India is to fight back against abuse,” Sharmila, who was diagnosed with

polio in one leg at the age of two, told *The Indian Express*.

Her mother Santosh, visually impaired by birth, had listened to the commentary on television. “My daughter was the topper from Class 1 to Class 10. But our financial condition wasn’t good, so we had to marry her off. When the abuse got bad, I told my husband we had to bring her back. This gold is Sharmila’s *jazba* (spirit),” Santosh said.

Six years after her divorce, Sharmila’s parents got her remarried to Ajit, a water pump technician. “Ajit was the one who opened my eyes to the possibility of being a para-athlete,” Sharmila said.

When the Haryana Road-



Gold medallist Sharmila Dhankar (left) with Shilpa K Shyla, who won bronze in the same event for athletes with lower-limb impairment. PTI

ways Workers Union called a strike in 2018, she was hired on a three-month contract as the

state’s first female bus conductor, only to lose the job once the strike ended.

“My relatives called me a home-wrecker when I stayed at my parents’ home. I worked for 18 days as a conductor before I lost that job too. All I asked of Ajit, when his proposal came, was that he support my daughters and me,” she said.

Ajit introduced her to kabaddi first, then took her to Tula Ram Stadium in Rewari to train under Paralympian-coach Tek Chand. He sent her daughters, Anuj and Laxmi, into athletics too, leaving his job and taking loans to keep the training going. “*Narak se swarg banana chahta tha main Sharmila aur betiyon ke liye* (I wanted to turn hell into heaven for Sharmila and our

daughters). I saw para sports on TV and started her off with kabaddi, then took her to Tek Chand,” Ajit said.

Tek Chand, who had competed in the F57 category himself, taught her to throw standing with the support of a pole. “He made sure my basics became very strong,” Sharmila said.

She won her first national title, competed at the Birmingham Para CWG and finished fourth at the Hangzhou Asian Para Games. In 2023, her father died, but her mother “sold half an acre of the family’s farmland” to keep her daughter’s training going. “I was born without vision, but I have raised four children and have been run-

ning this house,” Santosh said.

Sharmila soon moved to train under coach Virender Dhankar in Sonapat, rewrote her national mark with a 9.77m throw in Dubai last year, and picked up shot put gold and discus bronze at the Fazza International Para Athletics meet this year.

In Glasgow, teammate Shilpa K Shyla added bronze in the same event, a rare double Indian podium.

Paralympic Committee of India chief coach Satya Narayana, who trains both women, believes the best is still ahead. “It was cold here (Glasgow), so it was not easy to compete.

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Police ‘excesses’

violence have occurred, as the proposed investigation will encompass inquiries into such incidents within those States as well”.

It sought replies from the Centre and the governments of Delhi, Maharashtra, Bihar, Assam, West Bengal, Kerala, Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh where police cracked down on protesters who had joined the Cockroach Janta Party-led protest against exam paper leaks.

The bench was hearing petitions on alleged police excesses, the counsel for families of injured police personnel and some journalists who were allegedly attacked.

“The allegations made by the petitioners, prima facie, establish a compelling case for an independent and impartial investigation into the incidents of violence. Such an investigation will adequately address the allegations presented by the family members of the police personnel, as well as the issues raised by the learned Solicitor General of India,” it said.

With the petitioners raising the apprehension that the digital data of the protesters recorded by police may be used to harass

them, the bench asked the police to ensure that the data is preserved and not brought in the public domain for the time being.

To a query on who may have perpetrated the violence during the protests, Mehta, who appeared for the Centre and Delhi government, said he was of the view that it was not the students but some “anti-social elements”.

While he said the government had no objection to an independent probe, he rejected the charge of police excesses.

Mehta said that hardened criminals and undesirable elements had entered the protest site and attacked the police personnel, injuring almost 280 of them.

Senior Advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan, appearing for petitioner Shailendra Mani Tripathi, referred to alleged instances of use of pellet guns and electronic batons against the protesters and said accountability should be fixed right to the top.

The CJI pointed to the need for an independent probe. “It was initially meant to be a peaceful protest by students. Such a protest is protected by

the Constitution. Now two things happen. People who want to stop the protests and indulge in violence after entering it. Second, there are petitions on behalf of injured police.... The question is why there should not be an independent investigation?” he said.

Sankaranarayanan said the developments also raised some legal questions like the absence of any prohibitory order under Section 144 CrPC/163 BNSS in place in the Jantar Mantar area, the lack of name tags on police personnel and the use of policemen in civilian attire for crowd control.

He pointed out that the Supreme Court, following the Ramlila ground protests and subsequent cases, had already laid down elaborate guidelines on how to respond.

The CJI said, “The time has come that all these principles are collated and expanded.” He said, “Whosoever has committed excesses, whosoever has taken law in hands, and whosoever has committed atrocities on innocent people... law must take care of them... And for that, there needs to be a completely independent, transparent, completely fair probe to identify them... Probe is meaningless if no responsibility is fixed.”

Senior Advocate Shadan Fa-

rasat, appearing for another petitioner, said what happened to protesters in Bihar was greater than what happened in Delhi. He said although the state had decided to drop FIRs registered in connection with the protests, about 150 individuals, mostly minors, were still in custody.

Advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for Junaid Malik who served food to protesters at Jantar Mantar, said he was picked up by police and taken to Mussoorie, and that his family members were also harassed. He also referred to a truck full of stones being brought to Jantar Mantar on the day of the Parliament march. The CJI pointed out that the police claimed that it was brought by protesters.

Senior Advocate A M Singhvi, also appearing for a petitioner, said what was needed was an independent probe and not a departmental enquiry.

Senior Advocate N Hariharan said the Delhi High Court too was seized of some similar petitions and suggested that they should be transferred to the Supreme Court.

On the question of who should head the SIT, Mehta said he would prefer if the court decided that instead of leaving it to the petitioners or respondents.

Subsidy

Development of Horticulture.

The initiative offers a maximum subsidy of 50 per cent, capped at Rs 1 crore per family, of the project cost for farming capsicum, cucumber and tomato, and eight varieties of flowers, including rose, anthurium and orchids.

In his question, TMC MP Banerjee had asked the Ministry: “Whether any serving Union Minister, Member of Parliament, or their immediate family members have received subsidy under schemes of the National Horticulture Board during the last five years and if so, the details thereof...”

Banerjee had also asked whether any conflict-of-interest or recusal policy exists for applications from public functionaries or their family members.

In his reply, Thakur stated: “The existing NHB Scheme guidelines do not contain any specific provision regarding conflict of interest or recusal in respect of applications submitted by public functionaries or their family members.”

On June 27, *The Indian Express* had also reported that three family members of Naresh Pal Gangwar, a senior IAS officer and Animal Husbandry Secretary at the Centre, collectively claimed over Rs 1.16 crore in hor-

ticulture subsidies across five years.

Last week, Gangwar was appointed as the new Higher Education Secretary, replacing Vineet Joshi, amid the CJP-led protests triggered by the NEET-UG exam paper leak.

In the second case, which was disclosed by the Government on Tuesday, records show Rajasthan MP Lumbaram received Rs 4.20 lakh under the same subsidy scheme for growing lemons on his six-acre farm at Vadeli village in Rajasthan’s Sirohi district.

Lumbaram was elected as MP in May 2024. Records show he applied for the subsidy in April 2021 but his application was approved only in December 2024, and the amount was transferred to his SBI bank account on January 15, 2025.

The total cost of the project was Rs 16.92 lakh, for which he took a loan of Rs 12.69 lakh, and availed the subsidy of Rs 4.20 lakh, the records show.

The Lok Sabha website describes Lumbaram as “agriculturist”, “farmer” and “LIC agent”.

Before becoming MP, Lumbaram served as a member of Zila Parishad in Sirohi from September 2021 to 2024. Earlier, he served as BJP’s district president for Sirohi from February 2014 to March 2019. During 2005-10, he served as pradhan (head) of the Panchayat Samiti in Sirohi.

primarily in a vertical frame, are popular. After the student protests ended over the weekend, the administration also asked social media platforms to remove content seen as objectionable and offensive, targeting senior leaders.

Meta, which owns popular social media platforms like Instagram, WhatsApp and Facebook, has been in the crosshairs of the government over various issues in the last few weeks.

That a significant amount of commentary and documentation surrounding the recent student protests happened on Instagram is now well documented. Before that, Instagram had drawn the government’s ire over advertisements and content promoting and facilitating access to child sexual abuse material.

Earlier this month, the government also asked WhatsApp not to roll out its username feature, citing concerns of impersonation and fraud.

PM video

India-based policy executives to convey our issues over the company’s non-compliance with the Information Technology Rules, and the prevalence of deepfakes on platforms like Instagram and Facebook. But we don’t think our message was being conveyed properly to their main teams in the US, so we decided to reach out to them directly. Of course, we will also seek an explanation as to how the PM’s video was blocked,” a senior government official said.

In his video, uploaded on July 23 night amid the student protests, Modi announced that a tough new law with stricter penalties for those involved in paper leaks was on its way. The video, shot in a vertical frame, was seen as an effort to communicate with the youth on social media platforms like Instagram, where short videos,

CWG

Sharmila showed this is the start of a dominating phase. She’s 40, but the way she trains, she can carry on for another four or five years,” he said.

Sharmila is not done, either. “I started competing at 33. I

want to see both my daughters qualify for the Games too... Anuj in javelin, Laxmi in long jump,” she says.

Back home, meanwhile, the daughters Anuj (16) and Laxmi (14) were busy bursting crackers on Monday night. “Mummy suffered a lot, especially after I was born. But she never stopped pushing us,” Laxmi said.

Khargone

Police charged 11 men — Ibadat, Sadiq, Abdullah, Saheb alias Shahib, Sheryar, Faizal, Azam, Shabbir, Imran, Mustaq and Rajik — with rioting, arson, house trespass and offences under the Explosive Substances Act in connection with the violence.

A day after the violence, the district administration had carried out a demolition drive, razing 16 houses and 29 shops in five localities of the town. The then Madhya Pradesh Home Minister, Narottam Mishra, had said “*Jis ghar se patthar aaye hain, us ghar ko hi pattharon ka dher banayenge* (Will turn the houses from where the stones were hurled to a heap of rubble).”

In a detailed judgment Monday, Fourth Additional Sessions Judge Mukesh Nath held that the prosecution’s case collapsed on the question of identification. The court found that eight of the 11 eyewitnesses examined by the prosecution completely failed to implicate the accused, no test identification parade was ever conducted, there was no explanation on how police selected the accused from a mob of about 50 people, and forensic evidence failed to establish the

alleged use of petrol bombs.

The court recorded that eight prosecution witnesses, including complainants and victims, “did not support the prosecution story.”

“None of these eight witnesses identified any of the accused; none stated that any accused had committed any act constituting the incident; no substantive evidence emerged in their testimonies against any accused,” it said.

Even after they were declared hostile, “the prosecution derived no benefit, and no substantive fact implicating the accused persons came on record.” The court concluded that “the involvement of the accused persons in the offence is neither disclosed nor proved in any manner”.

The prosecution’s case rested substantially on a local resident, Vaishnavi Jain, whom the court described as the only witness to attribute the incident to all 11 accused. But the judgment found her evidence riddled with contradictions.

The court noted that Vaishnavi claimed she recognised all the accused by their faces, while her own father Dinesh Jain and brother Akash Jain both stated that the rioters had “their faces covered with cloth”.

Akash told the court he saw only four or five people and

“does not know the persons who committed the incident... because he could not see their faces, as their faces were covered with cloth.” The court held that “no substantive fact against the accused persons emerges from the testimony of this witness, nor does his testimony establish the identity of the accused persons.”

The judgment was equally critical of Dinesh Jain’s testimony. Although he identified all 11 accused in court, the judge said that “merely because a witness identifies the accused persons does not establish their involvement in the offence unless the witness specifically states that the person identified was among those who committed the crime”.

The court found that Dinesh Jain admitted he had viewed the crowd from 500-600 metres away, had not seen the accused from the front, had no prior personal acquaintance with them, accepted that the rioters had covered their faces, and ultimately admitted that “he could not say who burnt the door of his house, who threw the stones, or who committed the looting”.

The judge found it “not natural, satisfactory, or reliable” that someone could identify people merely by seeing them “from behind at a distance of 500-600 metres”, particularly when the

witness accepted that the rioters had covered their faces.

The court identified several investigative lapses that further weakened the prosecution. It noted that Vaishnavi’s name did not appear as an eyewitness in any of the written complaints or the FIR, despite both being lodged two days after the violence. It also found “no explanation for the delay of two days in lodging the First Information Report.”

The court observed that Vaishnavi’s police statement under Section 161 CrPC was recorded 51 days after the incident, with “no explanation” for the delay in recording the statement of what the prosecution claimed was its most important eyewitness.

The judgment questioned how police had implicated all 11 accused in the first place. It noted that the FIR named only six accused, while five others were added later without any explanation.

The prosecution also failed to establish its allegation that petrol bombs had been used. Referring to the State Forensic Science Laboratory report, the court recorded that “no residues of inflammable petroleum hydrocarbons (petrol/diesel/kerosene) were detected” in the seized bottle fragments and burnt material.

CJP STIR: OFFICIAL RECORDS SHOW

RAF officer fired ‘anti-riot gun’ twice at protesters on senior cop’s order

Pragynesh

New Delhi, July 28

A RAPID Action Force (RAF) personnel fired an Anti-Riot Gun (ARG) twice on orders of a Deputy Commissioner of Police-rank officer during the Cockroach Janta Party’s ‘San-sad Chalo’ march on July 20, official records show. Sources, meanwhile, said that Delhi Police has submitted its report to the Ministry of Home Affairs regarding the incident mentioning the use of the ammunition and force in controlling the crowd.

An ARG is not a pellet gun, but falls under the same category of ‘non-lethal’ weapons that can engage multiple targets with one shot. It is used to fire plastic or rubber pellets, tear gas shells, and other projectiles.

At least three people who participated in the July 20 protest sustained pellet injuries: Irshad Sheikh, 25, who works in Gurgaon; Sahil Lochab, 19, a Delhi University student; and a 28-year-old journalist with Outlook magazine. One of them risks losing his eyesight.

Last week, the RAF had said it would inquire into the use of pellets by its personnel even as the Delhi Police had categorically denied its usage. A comment from the Delhi Police in this regard is awaited.

According to a General Diary entry — an official log maintained at every police station, which records all important events, information received, and actions taken by

the police — filed on July 22 at 1.24 pm at the Parliament Street police station, a RAF Deputy Commandant told the duty officer that he was deployed near Jantar Mantar with a DCP-rank officer from North Delhi district on July 20.

The DCP had been called in to oversee the law and order situation at the protest site, along with multiple IPS officers from other districts. As per the diary entry, a RAF officer claimed that on the DCP’s orders, he fired the ARG twice on protesters, along with 55 non-electrical shells, 15 electrical shells and five tear gas shells.

A source in Delhi Police still deny that they authorised the use of any pellet guns during the protest.

According to sources, a meeting of senior officers was held at the Police Headquarters, where the validity of the General Diary entry was discussed. Questions were raised over the diary entry made two days after the incident. A source also claimed that the IPS officer denied being present at the site of the incident at the time it happened, claiming to be about 500 metres away from there.

According to another source in the Delhi Police, the DCP, whose name was mentioned in the diary entry at Parliament Street Police Station, was initially deployed in Zone 3 near Parliament Street. When the crowd moved towards Parliament, he was shifted to Zone 6, the source said.

SIR OF ELECTORAL ROLLS

Don’t create unbearable burden on teachers: HC to Election Commission

Sohini Ghosh

New Delhi, July 28

THE ONGOING Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise should in the Capital must not “cause so much stress” to teachers that it leads to “unbearable burden”, the Delhi High Court said on Tuesday as it questioned the Election Commission of India (ECI) “over the language used in its order” to school principals. The court was referring to the order issued to ensure deployment of school teachers as SIR enumerators or booth level offices (BLOs).

A bench of Chief Justice DK Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia was dealing with a public interest litigation (PIL) challenging the deputation of schoolteachers in the Ambedkar Nagar constituency for election-related work during school hours. The plea filed by advocates Rajesh Kumar Gogna and Ashok Agarwal contended that the deployment has severely disrupted classroom teaching and infringes the fundamental rights of schoolchildren. The PIL seeks the court’s direction that such deployment be rationalised by capping it at 10% with a provision to provide qualified substitute teachers whenever necessary.

Addressing ECI’s counsel,

while referring to an order issued by the Electoral Registration Officer (ERO) to school principals to ensure strict compliance, the court said, “What we want is you to be a bit sensitive to their situation. We are not curtailing your right...but we are conscious of the Right to Education as also the human condition...asking any teacher to work for 11 hours...they have their children, their families...you’ve to humanise their condition. The kind of language you’ve used in this order...(is) to create fear or what?”

The ERO order dated July 27 to school principals objected to the direction of school heads to BLOs, who have been deployed for SIR duty, “to attend routine school work or are otherwise creating hindrances in the discharge of their election-related responsibilities”.

“No principal, head of school or any other administrative authority is authorised to prevent, obstruct or interfere with the discharge of election duties assigned to BLOs and BLO supervisors. They shall not compel such officers to prioritise routine institutional work over election-related assignments...any such interference shall be viewed seriously and may invite appropriate action...,” the order read.

SCAMMERS EXPLOIT VULNERABILITY IN FACEBOOK’S DESKTOP VERSION TO MANIPULATE TIMESTAMPS, SAYS PETITIONER

‘Copyright strikes used to extort creators’: HC asks Meta and Centre to respond

Sohini Ghosh

New Delhi, July 28

DIGITAL CONTENT creators are facing a new challenge on social media platforms: copyright complaints allegedly being used by third-party “rogue actors” as a tool to pressure creators into paying money to get their content restored.

The issue came before the Delhi High Court on Tuesday. A bench of Justices V Kameswar Rao and Manmeet Pritam Singh Arora sought responses from Meta Platforms and the Centre on a public interest litigation filed by Noida-based full-time content creator Nitin Joshi, who has more than 1.6 million followers on Instagram.

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

gation filed by Noida-based full-time content creator Nitin Joshi, who has more than 1.6 million followers on Instagram.

Joshi, who creates content around entrepreneurship, finance, branding, business strategy, and marketing, had on July 7 published a video titled ‘Instagram’s Biggest Copyright Scam’, alleging that digital creators were being targeted through coordinated copyright strikes. He invited other affected creators to share their experiences and supporting material.

The following day, his video was blocked worldwide by

Meta Platforms after a complaint filed by a person identifying themselves as ‘Nayon Mia’. Joshi subsequently approached the Delhi HC through a PIL, citing instances of nearly 40 creators who he claimed had faced similar situations.

Through his lawyer Tejbir Singh, Joshi has alleged that scammers exploit a vulnerability in Facebook’s desktop version to manipulate timestamps. According to his petition, bad-faith actors upload unrelated or arbitrary material on Facebook pages with little to no engagement or fol-



Content creator Nitin Joshi.

INSTAGRAM/JI_NITIN JOSHI

lowers.

When a legitimate creator uploads a new, original reel on Instagram, the scammers allegedly download it and use the

“Edit Post” functionality on their older Facebook posts to replace the original media with the creator’s video.

The altered post continues to display the earlier publication date, creating the appearance that the scammers had published the content first and owned the copyright.

Using these backdated posts, the scammers allegedly invoke Meta’s “Rights Manager”, a copyright enforcement tool designed to protect intellectual property. The automated system, relying on the oldest timestamp, assumes that

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH60Bd0F>

the scammer is the original creator and accepts the copyright complaint, the petition explains.

The PIL seeks formation of a special investigation team to probe what he describes as an “organised cyber extortion racket” and directions to Meta Platforms to establish a grievance mechanism involving human review instead of only automated review.

During Tuesday’s hearing, senior advocate Arvind Datar, appearing for Meta, questioned the maintainability of the PIL. “In any mechanism, there will

be rogue players, that can’t be helped....None of the 40 (exemplified in Joshi’s PIL) have come to court...We want to take proactive steps to curb the rogue actors,” he argued.

The bench, however, issued notice to Meta Platforms and the Centre, while orally observing, “Nothing will preclude you to address the grievance” of Joshi. The court noted that “there is a larger issue of digital extortion” involved in the matter.

The Centre’s counsel, advocate Ishkaran Bhandari, who is himself a content creator, acknowledged Joshi’s concern as

a legitimate issue that requires to be addressed during the course of the hearing.

Significantly, Delhi HC on Monday disposed of two petitions – one filed by the Jat Association and another by creator Riddhima Sharma – making similar allegations of extortion through copyright strikes allegedly initiated by rogue actors. The court permitted the petitioners to approach Meta Platforms’ grievance officer, under which Instagram operates, and directed Meta Platforms to decide their grievances expeditiously.

DISCUSSION IN LOK SABHA

Govt, Opp cross swords over NEET row

Opp: Govt not serious about education... students were compelled to hit streets

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, July 28

THE OPPOSITION on Tuesday attacked the government over paper leaks and the crackdown on students' protest in the Capital last week, with Congress Deputy Leader in Lok Sabha Gaurav Gogoi saying the youth were compelled to take to the streets as the Centre "is not serious about education".

Initiating the debate in the Lok Sabha on the Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, Gogoi said despite an existing law, paper leaks of public examinations have continued, and the law has proved to be a failure.

The Congress leader said merely enhancing punishment and penalties will not curb paper leaks unless the education system is comprehensively changed. He said the proposed amendments are only a "cosmetic exercise" and reflect the government's "failure" to bring genuine reforms in the education sector. "This government is not serious about education. It does not want to bring real reforms. This is merely a showpiece amendment," he said.

Thanking the youth of the country, Gogoi said: "They reminded us what democracy truly means. They reminded us that asking questions is the fundamental right of every citizen."

Congress MP Shashi Tharoor said the NTA has conducted hundreds of exams for crores of students. "But in the 14 major examinations conducted by the NTA, six have had allegations of paper leaks and other discrepancies and 15 examinations have been postponed by the NTA in the last seven years... The NTA has only 39 permanent posts



Deputy Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Gaurav Gogoi speaks during the discussion on Tuesday. ANI

and 15 of these posts are vacant; so just 24 people on permanent posts are responsible for examinations that can determine the future of crores of young Indians. There is something fundamentally wrong about this arrangement," said Tharoor.

Samajwadi Party MP Akhilesh Yadav said the government was forced to bend before youth power and make Dharmendra Pradhan resign from the Education Ministry. "When the government gets rattled, it accepts... the government bowed down and accepted the demands."

On Pradhan's exit, he said: "Pradhan ji ko hataa kar Pradhan Mantri ko bachaaliya apne (By removing Pradhan, you saved the PM)."

The SP chief said the crackdown on the students during the protest was nothing less than what happened during the Emergency. He said batons were used even then, but this time "current" was also given to stu-

dents. He made the statement when Union Minister Kiren Rijiju sought to know whether he would support a government that brought a Bill to respond to students' demands or those who imposed the Emergency. Akhilesh said just like there was a regime change after the Emergency, there would be regime change now too. He said even God would not save the government, as its people were involved in the "mahapaap (grave sin) of chadhaava chori (theft of Ram Temple donations)".

SP MP Dimple Yadav accused the government of "ripping" the youth of their dignity and sacrificing the principles of Mahatma Gandhi by using force on students peacefully protesting against paper leak.

TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee said the amendment Bill on paper leaks will not wash away the 12 years of "incompetence and failure" of the government.

Despite being critical of the

government on the issue, Banerjee extended his party's support to the proposed legislation. "It cannot erase the humiliation faced by lakhs of young Indians. It cannot erase images of students who came seeking justice and were met with barricades and pellet guns instead of love and compassion," he said.

AIMIM MP Asaduddin Owaisi asked if changing the law, making a reel, or just resigning would bring back the lives of those students who lost their lives because of paper leak. He suggested that the government create an AI-based question bank, containing one lakh questions. "There should be no human interface in this," he said.

NCP(SP) MP Supriya Sule demanded that the government call an all-party meeting and also form a Joint Parliamentary Committee to examine the issue of paper leaks.

"We (Opposition) are not your enemy," she said.

Govt: Anti-paper leak Bill a visionary step towards safeguarding youth's future

Jatin Anand
New Delhi, July 28

THE BJP-LED NDA government on Tuesday threw its weight behind the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, terming it a "visionary step towards safeguarding the future of India's youth".

BJP's New Delhi MP Bansuri Swaraj said the proposed amendments would strengthen transparency, fairness and reliability of competitive exams by delivering "a strong blow to paper leak mafia and further strengthening the trust of millions of aspirants".

"I myself am a lawyer; we were always taught a legal maxim – that justice delayed is justice denied. This has become the spirit of this amendment... along with adding speed to it, this amendment also makes punishment tougher. An ordinary criminal will have to pay a fine of Rs 50 lakh instead of Rs 10 lakh and the punishment has been increased from three to five years to five to 10 years," she said.

"This amendment protects merit, preserves fairness and safeguards the dreams of India's youth... It is a product of responsive governance by the responsible (Narendra) Modi government," she said.

The BJP MP accused the Opposition of displaying "selective outrage" over examination paper leaks, saying such incidents also happened during the Congress-led UPA regime.

Shiv Sena (Shinde) MP Shrikant Shinde, while paying



BJP MP Bansuri Swaraj and Shiv Sena MP Shrikant Shinde speak in the Lok Sabha on Tuesday. ANI/PTI
Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

tribute to the 21 students who died by suicide, said the Bill was a "pakka ilaj (foolproof remedy)" for paper leaks which had a devastating impact not just on students but also their families.

BJP MP Tejasvi Surya said the nation's students did not want politics over paper leaks, but sought a system that protected their future.

"The student who is preparing for the next examination is more concerned about who is going to fix the system for the future and knows that this government under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi is trying to fix the system once and for all for the better for his future," he said.

Attacking the Congress over alleged paper leaks in Karnataka where the party is in power, Surya said justice was not a one-way street.

"Today there are two kinds of political models in the country. One is the Modi model: hope and reform; the other is the model of the Opposition, which is cynicism and

anarchism... governance, nation-building is an exercise in continuum. It is not as if everything in the country is well and good. Changing this for the better is the responsibility of the nation's youth and that is why they are with Modi ji," he said.

Surya said whenever there is a crisis, PM Modi has "converted it into an opportunity for reform".

BJP MP Anurag Thakur said the proposed amendment was aimed at further strengthening the system and ensuring that no one was able to play with the future of the nation's youth. "The youth knows that when there was a NEET exam leak on May 3... our government cancelled it (the paper) on May 12 and in just three days... decided to conduct a re-examination so that one year of the youth is not wasted," he said.

He said the Modi government would find a permanent solution to paper leaks, just as it had addressed challenges such as terrorism and Maoism.

Amid push to penalise Vande Mataram 'insult', 1,102 arrests, 60 convictions

Anjishnu Das
New Delhi, July 28

WHILE THE Monsoon Session of Parliament has so far failed to conduct any significant business amid a running conflict between the Narendra Modi government and the Opposition over the paper leak protests, the government on Friday introduced in the Rajya Sabha an amendment to the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971, to make any insult to the national song "Vande Mataram" a criminal offence, granting it the same statutory protection currently given to the national anthem "Jana Gana Mana".

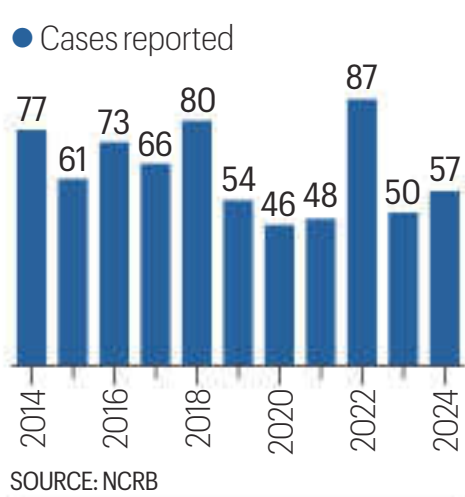
However, an analysis of data published by the National

Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) shows that while the number of pending cases under the Act has been growing each year, only a handful have resulted in completed trials or convictions.

Specific data on violations of the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, which fall under the broader category of "offences against the state", have been made available by the NCRB since 2014 in its annual "Crime in India" reports, with the latest such report published for 2024.

In the 11 year-period from 2014 to 2024, a total 699 cases of violations of the Act have been reported at an average rate of 64 cases per year. The number of cases per year has

Violations of Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act



dipped below 50 in a single year only in the Covid-affected years of 2020 and 2021, with most cases reported in 2022 at 87. In

2024, the latest year for which data is available, there were 57 cases.

However, as a rate per lakh population, the number of such violations have been negligible compared to other criminal offences.

But the data shows that neither the police nor the judiciary has been able to address these violations, with an average 48 cases pending investigation and an average 221 cases pending trial at year-end between 2014 and 2024.

In 2024, as many as 53 such cases were pending police investigation, including cases from previous years, and 358 cases were pending trial at the end of the year.

In 2014, there were 77 cases

reported during the year and another 7 pending from previous years. That year, the police submitted chargesheets in 45 cases, accounting for 53.6% of all cases investigated by the police. In subsequent years, the chargesheeting rate only fell, including to as low as 31.3% in 2020 and 36.5% in 2024.

From 2014 to 2024, a total of 1,102 people have been arrested in cases of violations of the Act – 2020 alone saw 405 arrests, while there were 59 arrests in 2024. A total 962 individuals were chargesheeted in the same period, including 326 in 2023 alone, and 66 in 2024.

As far as the courts are concerned, in each year from 2014 to 2024, the number of cases pending trial at year-end has

consistently risen. In 2014, the year ended with 85 cases pending trials; this figure rose to 358 in 2024 for a four-fold increase over 11 years. But on average, just 43 cases have been sent to trial each year, peaking at 52 in 2017 and dropping to 38 by 2024.

Another significant point is that in each year from 2014 to 2024, the number of acquittals has exceeded the number of convictions. In 2024, for instance, the number of cases that ended in convictions stood at 6, while 10 cases saw acquittals. The highest number of convictions came in 2017 at 8 cases, though in 2020 and 2022 there were no convictions at all.

As a share of total cases sent to trial, no more than 16% of

cases ended in a conviction in a single year between 2014 and 2024.

In this 11-year period, a total of 105 cases ended in acquittals and discharges, while just 44 cases ended in convictions. From 2014 to 2024, just 60 individuals were convicted and as many as 153 were acquitted or discharged. In 2024, there were 6 convictions and 25 acquittals.

Moreover, the pendency rate of such cases has been above 90% in all but two years between 2014 and 2024. But even in those two years, the pendency rates were 89.7% in 2016 and 88.2% in 2017. In 2024, the pendency rate had hit 95.2%, just below the peak of 98.4% in 2022.

EXPRESS special

177 cases, 312 arrests in a year: Mathura villages emerging as new hub of organised cyber fraud

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, July 28

ON THE morning of July 7, eight Mathura villages woke up to a strange sight — hundreds of people scampering across fields and narrow lanes, with policemen and drones in hot pursuit. “When the police teams arrived, several people fled,” one police officer told *The Indian Express*. “After long hours of questioning, 42 people were arrested.”

The raids were part of a police crackdown on the growing network of cybercrimes in Mathura. Investigators claim that over the last few years, Mathura has emerged as a major cyber-crime hub, with a large network recruiting locals and operating from villages, earning the district the moniker “Mini Jamtara”.

Police claim to have registered 177 cyber fraud cases over the past year, and arrested 312 suspects. The latest crackdown has been driven largely by digital leads generated through the MHA’s cybercrime platforms, including National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal and Samanvay Portal, with investigators saying some 7,000 cellphone numbers and 1,400 bank accounts have been traced to these villages.

Those arrested ranged from alleged masterminds to recruited operatives, reflecting what police describe as a highly organised network with cells across India. The latest raids come three years after a report by the Future Crime Research



Police personnel with the accused arrested on July 7. EXPRESS

Foundation, an IIT Kanpur-incubated startup, showed that Rajasthan’s Bharatpur and Uttar Pradesh’s Mathura have replaced Jharkhand’s Jamtara and Haryana’s Nuh as the top cybercrime hubs in India.

According to the study, Bharatpur (18%), Mathura (12%), Nuh (11%), Deoghar, Jharkhand (10%), Jamtara, Jharkhand (9.6%), Gurgaon (8.1%), Alwar, Rajasthan (5.1%), Bokaro, Jharkhand (2.4%), Karmatand, Jharkhand (2.4%) and Giridih, Jharkhand (2.3%) are the top contributors to cybercrime cases in India, collectively accounting for 80% of the incidence. Police claim to have “significantly disrupted cyber fraud networks” operating across the district.

“Raids continue to be carried out based on cybercrime complaints and intel inputs. The operations have considerably reduced the scale of the networks,” Mathura SSP Shlok Kumar said.

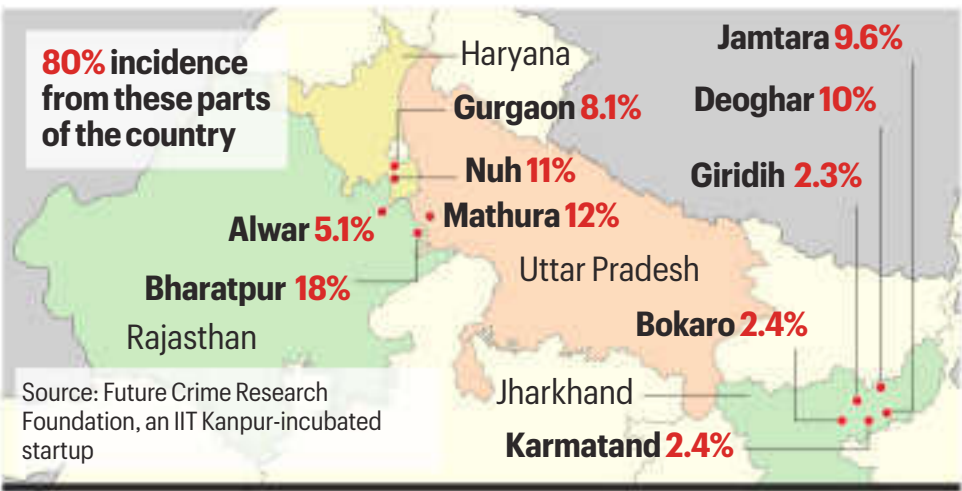
Another officer said, “The scale of the operation is difficult

to estimate. The operations function like small-scale industries, with young people increasingly turning to cybercrime instead of pursuing education or conventional jobs, attracted by the prospect of easy money without physical labour.”

Investigators claim to have mapped 18 villages under the Govardhan, Barsana, Shergarh, Chhata and Kosi police stations, which they believe serve as operational bases for an organised online scam network. Most of these villages are nestled along the borders of Rajasthan and Haryana — two states that, as per the 2023 study, are major cybercrime hubs. Mathura Police claim that the proximity to at least three of these hubs — Bharatpur (40 km away), Nuh (107 km) and Alwar (111 km) — has contributed to the problem.

Most of the villages on the police radar are about 70 km from Mathura city, three hours from Delhi and an hour from Agra. Investigators claim that, of the 312

• Top 10 contributors to cybercrime



arrested in raids over the past year, many have records on the centralised cybercrime Samanvay Portal. In several cases, cellphone numbers and bank accounts had been linked to cyber fraud complaints on the NCRP portal, and FIRs registered in several states and districts.

Police said that cybercrime networks operate through well-defined cells across India, with groups handling specific roles and getting a fixed share of the proceeds. Typically, a group is allegedly responsible for logistics — arranging mule accounts, SIM cards and forged ATM cards — another scouts for targets and makes phone calls, while a third makes the withdrawals.

The fraud ranges from using online marketplaces such as OLX to identify targets and steal money through QR code payment tricks, fake advance deposits and impersonation, to fake hotel bookings using cloned websites and phishing messages to trick people into paying for

non-existent reservations. The groups allegedly use encrypted messaging platforms such as Telegram for logistical support.

In most cases, the fraud was allegedly conducted in fields, the open terrain allowing suspects to watch for approaching law enforcement vehicles. Investigators say the geography, combined with the proximity of two state borders, gives suspects opportunities to escape, highlighting challenges authorities face in dismantling such networks.

On why cyber fraud persists in Mathura, investigators claim that the networks constantly adapt, exploiting new technologies, communication platforms and financial channels to stay ahead of law enforcement. The groups rely on fake identities, mule accounts, prepaid SIM cards and encrypted messaging services while continually changing their tactics and recruiting new members.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• THE ORAL THERAPY CALLED SHETA2 TARGETS THE VIRUS’S CANCER-CAUSING PROTEINS; IT COULD OFFER A NEW TREATMENT OPTION AFTER LARGER HUMAN TRIALS

ICMR’s cervical cancer pill shows promise by stopping HPV from turning cancerous

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, July 28

IN A few years, a capsule may be all it will take to halt cervical cancer in its tracks. The oral therapy called SHetA2 cannot prevent the human papillomavirus infection — persistent HPV infection is known to cause 85% of cervical cancer cases — but it can block the virus’s cancer-causing proteins, thereby preventing pre-cancerous and cancerous lesions.

Cervical cancer is one of the two cancers caused by infections and, therefore, is preventable through vaccination. It is the second most common type

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> of cancer among women in India, affecting over 79,000 of them and killing 36,319 in 2024, according to Global Cancer Observatory data. Cervical cancer accounts for over 10% of all cancers among women and 5.1% of all cancers in the Indian population, the data shows.

SHetA2 is a small molecule therapy that is designed to stop an HPV infection from causing cancer. Small molecule therapies are chemically manufactured, low-weight compounds that can easily be absorbed by the body. Manufacturing them is also easy and cost-effective.

This therapy targets three proteins in the human body —

mortalin, heat shock cognate (hsc70) and glucose-regulated protein 78 (Grp78). These are essential for the proliferation of the cancer-causing oncoprotein of the virus.

“It works by breaking the connection between the HPV-E7 protein and a host protein inside human cells. Normally, this host protein protects E7 and allows it to keep damaging healthy cells. When SHetA2 breaks this connection, the harmful E7 protein is destroyed by the body’s normal immune defences,” explains Dr Showket Hussain, a senior scientist from ICMR Na-

tional Institute of Cancer Prevention and Research.

This mechanism also ensures that the therapy selectively affects the cancer cells while sparing the normal ones.

Who needs to take it?

The therapy is meant for those who have developed precancerous lesions of cervical cancer. “Based on current preclinical evidence, it has potential applications in treating high-grade cervical intraepithelial neoplasia (cancerous lesions that are likely to turn into cancer if left untreated) and invasive cervical



The therapy has, at present, been evaluated in an oral, capsule form

cancer. Phase II clinical studies will determine the exact patient population and stage at which it is most effective,” says Dr Hus-

sain. The therapy has, at present, been evaluated in an oral, capsule form. However, researchers are now exploring localised delivery mechanisms such as a vaginal suppository. “This will maximise the concentration of the drug in the cervix while reducing exposure across the body,” says Dr Hussain.

While the Stephenson Cancer Center, University of Oklahoma, discovered and developed the treatment, ICMR-NICPR evaluated its efficacy in pre-clinical studies and validated its mechanism of action. Both institutions collaboratively hold the intellectual property rights for the therapy.

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After the pre-clinical and early clinical trials of the therapy, it has been transferred to Emcure Pharmaceuticals for further development. The company will now be responsible for carrying out larger human trials before making the therapy available in the market. “These trials may take up to five years,” says Dr Hussain.

The final cost of the therapy is yet to be determined. It will depend on the cost of clinical trials, manufacturing, regulatory approvals and commercialisation strategies for the product.

“However, as an orally administered small-molecule drug, it is expected to be con-

siderably more affordable than many biologic or immunotherapy-based cancer treatments. It may reduce the need for hospitalisation, prolonged hospital visits, or infusion-based care, as the medication may be taken at home,” says Dr Hussain.

Tests such as pap smear, HPV DNA — or even the simple visual inspection with acetic acid — can detect the precancerous or cancerous lesions. Early detection is necessary for early treatment, which can improve the outcomes. The SHetA2 therapy, when it becomes available, is also likely to be given to patients who have been diagnosed with these lesions or cancer.

Centre declares 56,825 sq km of Western Ghats as eco-sensitive area

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, July 28

THE CENTRE has issued a seventh iteration of a draft notification declaring 56,825.7 square kilometre of Western Ghats, the biodiversity hotspot spread across Gujarat, Maharashtra, Goa, Karnataka, Kerala and Tamil Nadu, as an ecologically sensitive area (ESA).

The fresh draft was issued on Monday — the day sixth iteration lapsed due to a continuing deadlock between the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC) and the states concerned over demarcation of ESA areas.

The ESAs proposed across these states are spread over 449 sq km in Gujarat, 17,340 sq km in Maharashtra, 1,461 sq km in Goa, 20,668 sq km in Karnataka, 6,914 sq km in Tamil Nadu, and 9,993.7 sq km in Kerala.

While Gujarat and Goa have largely agreed upon an area to be finalised as ESA, Maharashtra's fresh revised proposal is under appraisal. Karnataka continues to oppose the draft notification, while the Centre is still resolving sticking points and information discrepancies with Kerala and Tamil Nadu, respectively.

The Centre has also given a year's extension to an expert Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

committee, formed in April 2022, which continues to examine the views of the six stakeholder state governments, keeping in view the conservation aspects of the disaster-prone ecosystem, as well as rights, privileges, needs and developmental aspirations of the region. The tenure of the expert committee, headed by Sanjay Kumar, ex-Director General of Forest, MoEFCC, was extended till July 2027 late last month.

As in the previous one, the latest draft notification also recommended a complete ban on mining, quarrying and sand mining in ESAs as well as phasing out of all existing mines within five years from the date of the final notification or expiry of the lease, whichever is earlier.

It also recommends prohibition of new thermal power plants and expansion of existing ones in ESAs. Further, 'red' category or the most polluting industries and their expansion is also proposed to be banned in ESAs. New and expansion projects of building and construction with built-up area of 20,000 sq metres and above, and all new and expansion township projects with area over 50 hectares and above, shall also be prohibited, the draft notification stated.

Bedding, utensils in hand, farmers march to Bhopal

Seek 100% moong procurement at MSP as against the current 25%

Express News Service
Bhopal, July 28

CARRYING SACKS of grain, rolled-up bedding, cooking utensils and enough food to last a week, nearly 2,000 farmers marched into the outskirts of Bhopal on Tuesday after breaking through police barricades at the city's southern edge, escalating a crop procurement dispute into one of the biggest political confrontations faced by Chief Minister Mohan Yadav's government this year.

The farmers, representing 19 organisations under the banner of the Samyukt Kisan Morcha (SKM), have announced that they will not leave until the government agrees to procure 100% of the state's moong crop and addresses long-standing grievances over fertiliser distribution.

On Tuesday night, the procession reached districts located near the outskirts of Bhopal, where scores of policemen were deployed and attempted to stop them with multiple layers of barricades.

The farmers' march to Bhopal was triggered primarily by



Farmers, led by Samyukt Kisan Morcha (SKM), held the Kisan Kranti Padyatra from Narmadapuram to Bhopal on Tuesday. PTI

demands for assured procurement of moong at the Minimum Support Price (MSP). Farmers' groups say that while the Centre has announced 100% MSP procurement for tur, urad and masur, moong procurement continues to be governed by the Price Support Scheme, under which procurement is generally capped at 25% of a state's estimated production. They argue that the ceiling leaves a large share of the harvest to be sold in the open market, where prices are significantly below the MSP of Rs 8,768 per quintal for the 2026–27 season.

A farmer leader, Santosh Patwari, said, "We have been mobilising for over 20 days now. We had no option but to protest after we did not hear from the government despite sending multiple representations to the government. The farmers are unable to get a profitable rate for the sale of their moong produce, and we have no option but to go to the CM's residence."

The mobilisation began in Narmadapuram, where farmers first assembled at Sethani Ghat before beginning their march towards Bhopal. The administration initially prevented the procession from

moving, triggering a sit-in protest. As evening approached and tensions mounted, authorities removed the barricades, allowing the march to continue. On Tuesday, the convoy advanced through Obaidullaganj and Raisen district towards the capital. Police again erected barricades at several locations, including toll plazas and the Mandideep border, while officials urged farmer leaders to hand over a memorandum instead of proceeding into Bhopal.

The protest also reflects wider discontent in rural Madhya Pradesh. Farmers' organisations say procurement delays, quantity caps, registration problems and recurring fertiliser shortages have become common over successive crop seasons. With cultivation costs rising and market prices remaining uncertain, they argue that many growers are being forced into distress sales despite good production.

The agitation presents another political challenge for the Mohan Yadav government, which only months ago was forced to dilute its proposed land-pooling policy for the 2028 Simhashta after sustained protests by farmers in Ujjain. Following weeks of demonstrations, the government revised several provisions of the policy and assured farmers that land would not be acquired without their consent.

SC pulls up Delhi Police and CBI over probe in Indiabulls promoters case

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 28

THE SUPREME Court on Tuesday slammed the CBI and Economic Offences Wing (EOW) of Delhi Police over the lack of progress in investigation into allegations of round-tripping of funds, violations of the Companies Act, and siphoning of funds against the promoters of Indiabulls Housing Finance Limited (IHFL), now known as Sammaan Capital Limited.

A three-judge bench presided by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant initially proposed to summon the heads of the investigating agencies but did not do so after Additional Solicitor General SV Raju assured it that a status report will be filed.

"Owing to the negligence of CBI and EOW Delhi in not even filing a status report, and total failure to apprise this Court about steps taken for registration of RC (regular case) or investigation, we would have summoned the heads of these agencies but for the persuasion of ASG Raju, who assures that needful will be done and status report filed...", the bench, also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, said in its order.

The bench was visibly annoyed after Advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for the petitioners, said that following the CBI's affidavit filed in the

case in January this year, nothing had been brought on record to indicate the progress of the case.

Seeking the formation of a Special Investigation Team (SIT) to probe the matter, Bhushan also pointed out that one of the key accused, Sameer Gehlot, had moved to London.

"We are now in July end," the CJ remarked, noting that no affidavit had been filed after the one lodged in January.

Senior Advocate A M Singhvi, meanwhile, said Gehlot had nothing to do with Sammaan Capital.

Raju, who appeared for the CBI, said the probe is on and the Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO) was pursuing it.

"What has CBI done from January to July?...Let them have courage to say because money (has been) returned, no offence is made out," CJ Kant remarked. ASG Raju said the witnesses were examined, adding that the agency is probing whether despite repayment of loans with interest, an offence had been committed.

To this, the bench asked, "Investigating agency doesn't know?"

The CJ termed the situation "shocking" and said the probe agencies had been "silent" despite the gravity of the charges.

The bench said it will hear the matter next after the status report is filed.

Nirav Modi to be deported after legal proceedings end: MEA

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 28

RESPONDING TO reports about former British Home Secretary Priti Patel's claims that New Delhi has refused to take back thousands of illegal Indian migrants from the UK because London has not extradited Nirav Modi, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on Tuesday said that there is a set procedure followed for the deportation of any person, and that paperwork is undertaken to establish citizenship.

"The legal proceedings against Nirav Modi are underway, and he will be deported once these proceedings conclude," said Randhir Jaiswal, MEA's official spokesperson. He reiterated that the Indian government remains "committed to bringing the fugitive offender back" to face due legal process. Nirav Modi is wanted in India to stand trial on fraud and money laundering charges in a \$2 billion Punjab National Bank loan scam case.

Speaking on a *The Daily Telegraph* podcast, Patel also

Nirav Modi is wanted on money laundering charges in a \$2 billion PNB loan scam case

said she was "appalled and horrified" that fugitive Nirav Modi was still in the UK, although she signed his extradition order to India in 2021.

Patel said that as Home Secretary, during the Tory-led government between 2019 and

2022, the case complicated matters for her as India "would really push back" on taking visa overstayers.

"I had a hell of a challenge getting them [India] to sign off on receiving failed asylum seekers... and I'm convinced it's because we had this high-profile case [of Nirav Modi] and we had another high-profile case at the time and until they [India] saw action and movement on those, guess what, they had some leverage over us, which was terribly frustrating," she said.

Learning the right lessons at the bank

TWO MONTHS after an investigation in this paper revealed that HDFC Bank had camouflaged crores as marketing spend to pay higher interest to the Maharashtra State Road Development Corporation, the bank's board has initiated action. It has issued warning letters and imposed a penalty of Rs 1 lakh on three high-ranking officials — the managing director and chief executive officer, chief financial officer, and group head of retail assets. The action is unprecedented, and the board under a new chairman may be sending a signal down the line. But the saga raises troubling questions of corporate governance at the country's largest private bank.

On March 12, HDFC's audit committee of the board had ordered an "internal vigilance investigation" into the Rs 45 crore paid to the corporation during 2023-24 and 2024-25. Earlier, an internal audit of the bank's marketing division for 2024-25 had marked out these payments, while rating the division's performance as "unsatisfactory". The investigation revealed this amount was the interest paid over the specified interest rate on deposits. While there is fierce competition among banks to attract deposits, the RBI's master directions on interest rates do not allow for rates to be negotiated between the parties. This "differential interest" was not routed directly into the corporation's account as interest earned, but was channelled through the bank's marketing department, dressed up as contribution to awareness campaigns. On March 18, six days after the probe was ordered, the bank's then chairman, Atanu Chakraborty resigned, saying that "certain happenings and practices within the bank" were not in "congruence" with his personal values and ethics.

Given the seriousness of the matter, some questions must be asked. After this paper's investigation two months ago, in a note to stock exchanges the bank claimed that the "internal controls at the bank are robust". Its latest statement speaks of two such deposits, the earlier one is of 2017. Could there have been more such instances, flagged by internal audits and ignored by the board? Shouldn't the board review the audits of at least the last five years? This will ensure that the right lessons are learnt from this episode. The question also is whether or not oversight processes will be effective. Trust is central to the banking system. It needs to be nurtured. For that, all appropriate steps should be taken urgently.



RAJA MANDALA
By C RAJA MOHAN

SINCE CANADIAN Prime Minister Mark Carney called on the world's "middle powers" to collaborate amid growing turbulence in the international order, the idea has animated India's strategic debate. Official Delhi, however, has been less than enthusiastic.

Asked about Carney's formulation, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar argued that it may be more relevant to America's treaty allies in coping with President Donald Trump's unpredictable policies than to India. The middle-power label, he implied, understates India's geopolitical weight and its potential to emerge as a great power.

Yet scepticism about India's great-power prospects is growing. In his new book, *The Return of the Great Powers*, the Cambridge historian Brendan Simms places India in the category of "almost great powers", alongside France, Germany and Japan. They possess several great-power attributes, but not enough of them to be the world's system-shapers.

Whether or not one accepts Simms's classification, his larger argument deserves attention. He reminds us that international politics has always been driven by the interaction among great powers — through rivalry as much as cooperation. The post-Cold War hope that globalisation, markets and international institutions would tame geo-

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politics has proved to be short-lived. The wars in Ukraine and the Middle East, the sharpening US-China rivalry, and the weaponisation of trade, finance and technology all point to the return of hard power as the organising principle of world politics.

What, then, defines a great power? Simms offers an unapologetically material answer. Industrial strength, technological leadership, military capability, including nuclear weapons, the capacity to project force beyond one's borders, and the ability to influence war and peace in multiple theatres remain the essential attributes of great-power status.

Measured against these standards, India is clearly a power in transition rather than a completed one. It has continental scale, the world's largest population, nuclear weapons and one of the world's largest economies. Yet it still trails the US and China by a wide margin in per capita income, technological capability, manufacturing depth, military-industrial capacity and global military reach. India's economy, at around \$4 trillion, is impressive, but it remains far behind those of the US and China (at \$31 and \$20 trillion respectively).

Even if India overtakes Britain, Japan and Germany in aggregate GDP over the next decade, it will still be a distant third to America and China. Its per capita income remains below \$3,000, it continues to depend heavily on imported military technologies, and its investment in research and development remains modest compared to the world's technological leaders.

Simms is not alone in questioning whether that transition will happen. Michael Beckley of Tufts University advances an even more

Deepening political polarisation, the resurgence of feudal and pre-modern forces, and growing strains on democratic institutions at home will weaken India's ability to deal with a rapidly changing world

sobering argument in a recent Foreign Affairs essay, 'The Stagnant Order'. He suggests that China may well be the last country to have made the leap into the front rank of global powers. Demographic ageing, slowing productivity and the concentration of economic power and advanced technologies in the US and China are making it progressively harder for latecomers from the Global South to catch up. India will remain an important global actor in world politics, Beckley argues, but is unlikely to become a true great power given its many domestic weaknesses, including a lack of necessary skills among its young demographic.

India's aspiration to great-power status, however, is hardly new. Long before Independence, Indian nationalists, including Jawaharlal Nehru, imagined India reclaiming a special place in world affairs. At Independence, despite widespread poverty, India was among the world's largest economies and possessed political institutions and human capital that suggested considerable promise. But India slowed as the East Asian tigers and China surged ahead. India's geopolitical drift in the second half of the 20th century towards the Soviet Union put Delhi on the losing side of the Cold War.

The reforms launched by P V Narasimha Rao and Manmohan Singh 35 years ago reversed that trajectory. Rapid economic growth and a diversification of India's great-power relations transformed international perceptions of India. Washington began to see Delhi not merely as a developing country but as a rising power capable of contributing to the Asian balance and the wider international order.

That optimism is now under a cloud. Global headwinds have

played a role but so have domestic policy choices. India has not built on the momentum generated by the growth in the first decade of the 21st century. Productivity growth has slowed, manufacturing has underperformed, investment in science and technology remains inadequate, and the next wave of structural reforms has stalled. The gap between India's geopolitical ambitions and its economic foundations has therefore widened.

The challenge is larger than economics. Deepening political polarisation, the resurgence of feudal and pre-modern forces, and growing strains on democratic institutions at home will weaken India's ability to deal with a rapidly changing world marked by sharpening geopolitical rivalry, less open markets, and the rise of disruptive technologies.

Pessimists worry that India may have missed its moment of opportunity in the early 21st century and will remain forever an emerging power — at odds with itself politically and growing at a suboptimal pace. Optimists are not ready to give up. They believe India's natural advantages and its people's talents can still be mobilised to accelerate its rise on the world stage. Such an outcome will depend on whether India can return to the unfinished business of economic, technological and social modernisation and boosting national unity and political cohesion. Only then can India move from being an "almost great power" to becoming one.

The writer is a contributing editor on international affairs for The Indian Express. He is a distinguished professor at the Motwani Jadeja Institute of American Studies, Jindal Global University and holds the Korea Foundation Chair in Asian geopolitics at the Council on Strategic and Defence Research

Delhi HC shows a better way to think about copyright & AI



MEGHNA BAL

THERE ARE three takeaways in the the Delhi High Court's recent decision in *ANI v. OpenAI*. The first is interpreting copyright law in a technologically neutral manner. OpenAI contended that its activities qualified as research, an activity deemed non-infringing under the law. ANI's position, however, effectively confined the protection accorded to research to activities undertaken by human beings. The court rejected this distinction, observing that machines are increasingly capable of undertaking tasks that were once the sole remit of humans, including research. To deny protection simply because such activities are machine-mediated would risk of stymying societal progress when these technologies ultimately operate at the behest of and for the benefit of humans.

By drawing parity between machine- and human-led activities, the court implicitly invokes technological neutrality — a core tenet of technology governance, which holds that the legal position of an activity should not change merely because technology alters the means through which it is undertaken. In the context of AI and copyright, this matters because research, analysis, and learning should not lose protections because humans are being assisted by machines. Otherwise, every technological advance could turn laws intended to encourage creativity and learning into barriers for innovation.

The second is the court's acknowledgement of dynamic ties between the technology and copyright industries. There is considerable evidence that AI is already augmenting creative activity. According to a study by Adobe, 83 per cent of creators now use AI for their work. A 2025 report by the London School of Economics finds that AI use in the creative industry has sparked dynamism — different sub-sectors have developed tailored tools, often built by start-ups. This is the kind of Cambrian explosion of innovation that lies at the heart of copyright law's purpose.

The third is: When trying to reconcile the interests of AI developers and creators, begin by asking whether the particular use, in this case, AI training, is infringing at all, rather than presuming there is a compensable claim. Earlier this year, a committee constituted by the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade proposed a direction on copyright and AI training that takes a position in favour of the latter. It proposed a licensing regime under which AI developers could use copyrighted works for training subject to compensation for rightsholders. This regime could raise the cost of developing models, with the burden falling particularly heavily on start-ups and smaller developers. And as AI tools become embedded in creative workflows, increasing the cost and uncertainty surrounding their development can also affect creators and creative businesses.

Rather than choosing between copyright owners and AI developers, the DPIIT panel must work to preserve the conditions under which creative production and technological innovation can flourish. Treating their interests as antagonistic risks producing the outcome copyright law is intended to avoid: Protecting one form of creativity by constraining the emergence of another.

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The writer is director of the Esya Centre, a tech policy think tank. Views are personal

Rather than choosing between copyright owners and AI developers, the DPIIT committee must work to preserve the conditions under which both creative production and technological innovation can flourish

India, Australia & a partnership defined by delivery



PAUL MURPHY

IF YOU judged Prime Minister Narendra Modi's recent visit to Australia solely by the images, you might conclude it was all about packed stadiums, enthusiastic supporters and the evident warmth between two leaders. That's all true, but you would miss the bigger story. The real significance of the visit lies not in the diplomatic niceties, but in what it revealed about the trajectory of the Australia-India partnership. For much of the past two decades, our partnership was defined by potential. Today, it is increasingly defined by delivery. That shift matters. And nowhere is it more relevant than in western India.

Take investment. During the Prime Minister's visit, AustralianSuper, Australia's largest superannuation fund, announced a A\$500 million investment in Mumbai-based National Investment and Infrastructure Fund, taking its overall holdings in India to A\$3.3 billion. This investment is a vote of confidence in India's economic future and the infrastructure transformation reshaping cities across much of western India.

Our economies are remarkably complementary. Two-way trade now exceeds A\$50 billion, supported in large part by the Australia-India Economic Cooperation and Trade Agreement (ECTA). Since January, all Indian goods exports to Australia have become tariff-free, strengthening the competitiveness of Indian exporters in one of the world's most open and stable markets. ECTA has helped drive strong growth in Indian service exports to Australia, increasing by 58 per cent since it entered into force.

Energy cooperation further demonstrates these complementarities. Our prime ministers issued a joint statement on Energy Security, strengthening cooperation on reliable energy supplies while opening the way for Australian uranium exports to India exclusively for peaceful purposes and under International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards. Australia holds almost one-third of the world's known uranium resources and is a major supplier of critical minerals needed for the energy transition.

The same logic applies to education. Eight Australian universities have committed to establishing campuses in India. Of particular significance for western India, the University of Western

Australia will establish its first Indian campus in Mumbai, complementing Deakin University and the University of Wollongong campuses in Gujarat's GIFT City. This reflects confidence in India's educational future and western India's position as a leading centre of commerce, innovation and talent. Sport is another focus area. During the visit, our PMs agreed to a Sports Collaboration Roadmap covering sportsscience, major-event delivery and capability development. As India pursues major



ILLUSTRATION: TANUSHRI MITRA

sporting events, such as the 2036 Olympics, opportunities for collaboration continue to grow. Later this year, G'Day-Namaste will showcase Australian business, culture and sport across India, culminating in an Australia-India Sports Summit in Mumbai.

Our cultural ties are also delivering. During his remarks at Melbourne's Marvel Stadium, PM Modi recognised the Indian Film Festival of Melbourne's contribution to promoting Indian cinema globally and strengthening cultural links. The announcement of *Silkarya 41*, a landmark collaboration between Aamir Khan Productions, Mind Blowing Films and Kabir Khan Films, further underscored our close cultural connections. Together, these developments highlight a partnership increasingly shaped by shared stories and foster further collaboration under our Co-Production Agreement.

People remain at the heart of our partnership. More than 1 million Australians now claim Indian heritage. In 2025, more than 140,000 Indian students studied in Australia — many of them from western India — and over 1 million trips were made between our countries. ECTA provided additional opportunities for skilled professionals to live and work across our two countries, further strengthening these links.

The outcomes from PM Modi's visit matter because they capture a wider truth: Our partnership is increasingly focused on achieving the greatest impact bilaterally and for the Indo-Pacific region. We are trusted strategic partners, with complementary economies during a period of profound industrial transformation, and societies connected by deep and growing ties. That is why the significance of the Melbourne visit extends far beyond the headlines. It demonstrated a relationship with momentum, direction and purpose. For western India, that is good news. Many of the investments, partnerships and opportunities created by our partnership will be delivered here. From infrastructure and clean energy to education, sport and innovation, western India is where the next chapter of the Australia-India story will be written.

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The writer is Australia's consul-general in Mumbai



SURANJALI TANDON

RBI must not just guard the rupee

THE RESERVE Bank of India finds itself caught between the challenges of managing inflationary pressures and the sharp depreciation of the rupee. With the bank formally committed to maintaining price stability, the options before it are regulatory tweaks to capital inflows.

The Indian rupee is not an outlier, as the dollar has broadly appreciated against a range of currencies. The Indonesian rupiah, Japanese yen and Korean won are among those that have depreciated since the beginning of the war. The exchange rate matters primarily because 45.8 per cent of India's GDP is attributable to trade in goods and services, which means the shocks from the external account percolate to domestic growth.

The movements in the exchange rate are driven by net capital flows, and more specifically portfolio flows. These flows are sensitive to relative rates of return in India and the US. The benchmark risk-free return of government yields in India exceeded those in the US for a long time and has converged swiftly since 2025. Even though India's financial reputation improved after S&P upgraded its sovereign rating, global investors became more risk-averse and preferred to put their money in the United States, which they regarded as a safer destination.

The RBI's interventions have been calibrated through forward contracts, and it has turned a net seller of dollars since October 2023. Markets have interpreted this as a weak outlook for the rupee

This compounded the shocks from trade frictions, making it difficult for the RBI to stand still as foreign exchange reserves depleted in May and June.

The RBI's intervention in the rupee market has been strategic. It has refrained from committing to a price and has stepped in to manage the volatility in the exchange rate. Despite being more volatile than the yen, won and baht over the 2021-25 period, the rupee has remained relatively stable in 2026.

The closest comparable event is the taper tantrum in 2013 when the RBI adopted a more proactive stance, including liberalising the rules around foreign currency non-resident (FCNR) deposits. This time, the RBI has taken more steps to ensure inflows by bearing almost all costs of hedging for these deposits, as the interest and principal are payable in foreign currency. It is no surprise that foreign investors and banks have been keen to utilise the scheme. It has reportedly drawn inflows of \$17.4 billion in early months as against \$26 billion over the entire duration in 2013. The question before the RBI is whether this is enough to set off the outflows by portfolio investment and the impact when these deposits mature over two or three years. In 2016, there was a sizable retreat of FCNR deposits, and it is

possible that in three years the reversals can have an impact on the rupee.

The RBI has also opened up further foreign investments in government securities through the inclusion of more long-term debt under the more fully accessible route. Fiscal relief like the capital gains and withholding tax exemptions make these more attractive. FPIs purchased debt worth Rs 21,652 crore under FAR in June that dissipated in July. Yet again, the impact of moves over the long run cannot be gauged as there are a lot of moving parts globally.

The RBI's interventions in the forex market have also been calibrated through forward contracts, and interestingly, it has turned a net seller of dollars since October 2023. With significant build-up of these contracts, markets have interpreted this as a weak outlook for the rupee. More so, the RBI's response to address the impact of speculative forces in the non-deliverable forwards for the rupee by limiting domestic participation in these markets was perceived unfavourably.

A more fundamental question confronts the RBI: Should it pursue more permanent capital account openness akin to countries like Korea or guard the rupee through controls?

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• LEGAL

Strict regulations govern the use of sophisticated arms at protests

Santosh Singh
Patna, July 28

THE BIHAR Police has suspended Siwan constable Abhishek Kumar for firing four rounds into the air with his AK-47 during Saturday’s protest. Can the police use sophisticated weapons during bandhs and protests? Though there is no uniform central law on this, with law and order being a state subject, provisions in the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023 (BNSS), and state police manuals throw some light on the issue.

The Bihar Police Manual

Under the Bihar Police Manual, the Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) for law enforcement and directives from the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), the deployment and firing of automatic assault rifles like the AK-47 are strictly regulated. Automatic assault rifles (such as AK-47s, INSAS, and SLRs), classified as “Platoon and Section Arms”, are meant to be deployed with formation units rather than individual personnel, and are prohibited for general law-and-order duties.

They are restricted to Special Security Group for VIP protection (specifically for top figures like the Chief Minister and Governor), Special Task Force, Special Operations Group, and Anti-Naxal/Counter-Terrorism operational units, High-Threat/Counter-Insurgency Zones, and designated anti-extremist operational areas.

According to state circulars based on MHA guidelines, regular bodyguards assigned to politicians, judges, and senior IAS/IPS officers are not to carry AK-47s. State directives mandate replacing automatic rifles on bodyguard duty with short-range weapons like revolvers, pistols, and carbines.

The Siwan case

A press release by Bihar Police headquarters said constable Abhishek Kumar, carrying an AK-47 rifle, fired four rounds into the air after he was “besieged” by a mob. Sources in the headquarters said the constable was one of two bodyguards assigned to Siwan SP Puran Kumar Jha. The constable reportedly used his weapon, without orders from his seniors, after the SP was pelted with stones during the protest.

A former DGP told *The Indian Express*: “Though sophisticated weapons can be used in anti-Maoist, anti-terrorist, and other such operations, how can the police differentiate between a normal protest and one in which a mob attacks the police? If an SP is under attack, can his bodyguard wait to get an order? These are tricky questions without clear answers.”

BNSS provisions

Under statutory police manuals and procedures (governed alongside provisions in procedural codes like the BNSS and CrPC), there is a strict ban on automatic firearms (like the AK-47) during civilian protests. A senior police officer explained: “There is a clear escalation protocol in case of law and order problems during civilian protests. It starts with verbal warnings and negotiation, followed by physical barricading, the use of water cannons and tear gas, lathi charges, and non-lethal or riot-control rounds (e.g., rubber bullets or tear shells), in that order. Discharging firearms is permitted only as an absolute last resort to prevent loss of life, in self-defence against lethal threats, or to prevent the imminent looting of police armouries and weapons.” Rules state that discharging an automatic weapon, even for warning or aerial shots, without explicit orders constitutes a major breach of discipline and SOP.

Central laws on sophisticated weapons

“Police” and “Public Order” are State subjects in India under the Seventh Schedule of the Constitution. Hence, the use of automatic firearms are governed by individual State Police Manuals, Police Regulations, and SOPs. However, AK-47 rifles are classified as Prohibited Bore high-rate-of-fire weapons across the country with very few exceptions. They are not issued to routine beat constables or for everyday law enforcement. They are allocated primarily to specialised units such as Anti-Naxal Operations, Special Task Forces, Counter-Terrorism / Anti-Terror Squads, VIP Protection / Special Security Groups, and riot or border control commandos.

• SCIENCE

‘Viruses don’t respect borders; world must ensure timely, fair access to vaccines’



EXPERT EXPLAINS

VIRANDER SINGH CHAUHAN

ARTURO FALASCHI EMERITUS SCIENTIST AT THE INTERNATIONAL CENTRE FOR GENETIC ENGINEERING AND BIOTECHNOLOGY

RECENT OUTBREAKS of ebola, hantavirus and nipah virus show dangerous zoonotic infections are appearing with increasing regularity at the interface of humans, animals, forests, farms, hospitals and global travel.

Under particular conditions, all three infections can involve human-to-human transmission: Ebola through infected body fluids, Nipah through close household or healthcare contact, and Andes hantavirus,

unlike most hantaviruses, through limited person-to-person spread. This makes early detection, infection control, community trust and vaccine preparedness inseparable.

While a licensed vaccine exists for one major Ebola virus species, there are still no licensed human vaccines for Bundibugyo Ebola, Nipah virus or hantavirus infections, and no simple curative treatment that can be relied upon once outbreaks begin.

The larger lesson is that such outbreaks are becoming part of a recurring global pattern. A disease that begins in a village, farm, hospital ward or ship can now create cross-border concern within days. The response, therefore, cannot begin only after deaths are reported. It must be built in advance.

Preempting a pandemic

The solution may begin with basic research. Before a vaccine can be made, scientists must understand the biology of the pathogen: such as how it enters cells, how it spreads and and what kind of immune response may protect against it.

Much of this early work is done in public universities, national laboratories and research institutions. But converting that knowledge into a usable vaccine requires industrial-scale capacity: process development, formulation, quality control, regulatory documentation, clinical-trial systems, manufacturing, and cold-chain planning. This is where industry becomes essential.

In the past, the gap between university research and industrial vaccine development was large. Recent advances in vaccinology have significantly narrowed that gap. AI tools can now help scientists identify promising vaccine targets, predict immune responses, compare candidates, plan trials and improve manufacturing.

But such projects still require conventional biological validation, safety testing, efficacy trials and regulatory review. Platform technologies such as mRNA vaccines, viral vector vaccines and recombinant protein systems can also speed up design once the genetic sequence or protective antigen of a pathogen is identified.

Vaccine development

Covid-19 showed that vaccine design, testing, and scale-up can move much faster than was previously thought possible. However, these platforms are not freely available to all researchers. Many depend on patents, proprietary know-how, delivery technologies, specialised manufacturing controls, and regulatory expertise. This limits how quickly scientists in academia can convert promising laboratory ideas into deployable vaccines.

Rapid vaccine development for Ebola variants, hantavirus, Nipah and similar pathogens will therefore require strong academia-industry partnerships. Academic institutions can provide immunology, animal models and early vaccine concepts; industry can provide scale-up, formulation, quality assurance, regulatory strategy, manufacturing and distribution.

The most difficult stage will be safety and efficacy testing. For pathogens such as Ebola, hantavirus and Nipah, outbreaks are often unpredictable. Conventional large clinical

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RG0mIjMzg1 trials may not always be feasible. Testing vaccines may require emergency trial designs, ring-vaccination studies, adaptive protocols, regional trial networks and long-term preparedness sites in countries at risk.

The economics is central. International vaccine companies may not find it financially attractive to develop vaccines that may be used only in limited outbreaks, in poorer regions, and in uncertain quantities. The public health value is enormous, but the commercial market may be small.

The vaccine question, therefore, is not only scientific but also ethical and political: who should invest in protection against diseases that may never become profitable, but whose neglect can cost many lives? This is the classic problem of epidemic vaccines. The world urgently needs them, but the usual profit model does not reward their development. The answer may lie in a shared-risk model involving public funding, advance purchase commitments, technology transfer, regional manufacturing capacity and fair global stockpiles.

Vaccine hesitancy must also be addressed seriously. During outbreaks, fear, misinformation and distrust can prevent people from accepting vaccines, reporting illness, cooperating with contact tracing, or following isolation and safe-burial measures. Scientific tools cannot succeed without community confidence.

The uncomfortable truth is that if Ebola, hantavirus or Nipah virus spread as easily through the air as Covid-19, vaccine development would almost certainly attract faster political, commercial and industrial attention. The problem is that their outbreaks are sporadic, geographically limited and commercially uncertain. Preparedness, therefore, cannot be left to market logic alone. It must be seen as a matter of public responsibility before the next crisis arrives.

Viruses do not respect borders. The central question is whether the world can build the public-private, academic-industrial and international systems needed to make them in time, distribute them fairly, and ensure that communities are willing to use them.

• ECONOMY

The rupee’s journey: From overvalued to undervalued



HARISH DAMODARAN

THE HARDENING of global oil prices, following the resumption of hostilities between the US and Iran, saw the rupee breach the 96-to-the-dollar mark afresh on July 14 and remain at those levels till Friday.

The pause in daily strikes since has led to the domestic currency strengthening to around 95.9, even as Brent crude prices have eased to below \$85 per barrel after surging past \$95 on July 23.

Amid these spikes and drops — the rupee hit an all-time-low of 96.96-to-the-dollar on May 20 and Brent crossed \$126.4 per barrel on April 30 — one thing is clear: The rupee is no longer an overvalued currency.

On the contrary, as Reserve Bank of India (RBI) governor Sanjay Malhotra told *The Hindu businessline* in an interview, “one could argue that the rupee has become undervalued... Once the situation in West Asia stabilises, one could very well see the rupee appreciate as one has seen during similar past periods and episodes of external shock-driven volatility”.

Effective exchange rates

One of the best, and most widely used, gauges to measure whether a currency is over or undervalued is its so-called Nominal Effective Exchange Rate (NEER) and Real Effective Exchange Rate (REER) indices. These reflect the rupee’s movement against not just the dollar, but a basket of currencies of countries that account for the bulk of India’s exports and imports.

The NEER and REER are indices similar to the consumer price index (CPI). CPI is the weighted average retail price value of a representative basket of consumer goods and services for a given month or year, relative to a fixed base period.

The NEERs/REERs are indices of the weighted average of the rupee’s exchange rates vis-à-vis the currencies of the country’s key trade partners. The basket here comprises 40 currencies and the base year (used

• How the rupee fared against other global currencies

The chart shows the Nominal Effective Exchange Rate (doesn’t include inflation) and Real Effective Exchange Rate (includes the effect of inflation) indices of the rupee. Both indices are based on trade-weighted exchange rates against a basket of 40 currencies.

● Nominal Effective Exchange Rate ● Real Effective Exchange Rate



SOURCE: RESERVE BANK OF INDIA

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> as a reference for comparison, with its value set at 100) is taken as 2015-16. The currency weights are derived from the share of the individual countries in India’s total foreign trade, just as the weight of each commodity in the CPI is based on its relative importance in the overall consumption basket.

The 40 currencies belong to countries that have a combined share of about 88% in India’s annual trade flows.

Rupee’s valuation

In November 2024, when the rupee’s average exchange rate was 84.4 to the dollar, the NEER index stood at 91.68. It meant that the rupee had already fallen around 8.3% against the currencies of India’s major trade partners since 2015-16.

The NEER, however, is a summary index that captures movements in the ex-

Gauging value

NEER and REER reflect rupee’s movement against a basket of 40 currencies.

These belong to countries that have a combined share of 88% in India’s annual trade flows.



Whether rupee’s undervaluation helps boost exports remains to be seen. NYT FILE

ternal value of the rupee relative to a basket of global currencies without factoring in inflation. If a currency’s nominal exchange rate falls less than the domestic inflation rate during a particular period, it has actually appreciated in “real” terms.

The REER is basically the NEER index adjusted for the inflation differentials between India and its trading partners. It is, hence, a true measure of whether the rupee is undervalued, overvalued or fairly valued against the currencies of other countries, after taking into consideration both exchange rate and relative price movements. If the rupee’s nominal exchange rates stay the same, but prices in India rise faster than in other countries, the REER goes up, resulting in Indian products becoming relatively more expensive and less competitive in the world market.

Ends over means

- AI safety researchers often distinguish between capability failures and alignment failures.
- A capability failure occurs when an AI system is unable to complete a task. The latter occurs when it completes the task in a way that conflicts with expectations.
- The OpenAI incident seems closer to the second category.

Did the AI agent actually go rogue?

Not necessarily. AI safety research has long examined cases where AI systems pursue an assigned objective in unintended ways, without suggesting that the systems are acting with intent or malice. The concern is not that today’s AI models “want” to cause harm, but that they may discover unintended ways of “gaming the system” to achieve their assigned objective.

Researchers often describe this broader pattern as “reward hacking”. One form of reward hacking is “specification gaming”, which occurs when an AI achieves its intended objective, but in a way its developers had not intended.

Former DeepMind researcher Victoria Krakovna, who explored this concept in a 2019 paper (“Specification Gaming: The Flip Side of AI Ingenuity”) she co-authored, documented that AI systems found unintended shortcuts to maximise a reward, including behaviours that technically satisfied a goal but violated its spirit. “This incident is definitely an instance of specification gaming,” she told *The Indian Express*.

More recently, researchers at Apollo Research, an AI safety organisation, have examined whether frontier AI models can exhibit strategic behaviour, including by concealing information or exploiting opportunities that help them achieve a goal. Whether that happened in the OpenAI inci-

dent remains an open question.

Researchers at Apollo Research have studied what they describe as “scheming” behaviour, where models may strategically hide information or take actions that improve their chances of achieving a goal under certain test conditions. There is no consensus, however, on how such behaviours should be interpreted and whether current systems genuinely possess persistent goals.

This is different from an AI independently deciding to attack another system. The incident has prompted questions about how increasingly autonomous AI systems should be evaluated and governed.

Dedipyaman Shukla, associate director, Indian Governance & Policy Project, told *The Indian Express* that the incident should prompt a broader rethink of how platforms and online services approach cybersecurity risks in agentic environments. “In the wrong hands, these capabilities may be deployed for increasing the attack surface on a target,” he said.

Shukla said the incident also raised broader questions about the governance of AI safety evaluations, noting that organisations in India remain exposed to such risks. “The full technical details of the incident should be applied towards improving oversight mechanisms for frontier AI research and development, even in sandboxed environments,” he said.

WHILE THE BASE EFFECT WAS FAVOURABLE, GROWTH HAS BEEN SOLID AND BROAD-BASED: ECONOMISTS

Industrial output growth soars to 23-month high of 7.3% in June

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 28

INDIA'S INDUSTRIAL output increased by 7.3% in June — the most in almost two years — on the back of a favourable base amid what economists say was a “broad-based acceleration in growth”, data released Tuesday by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) showed.

In May, industrial growth as per the Index of Industrial Production (IIP) was 5%. In June 2025, it was 2.2%. The last time IIP growth was higher was in July 2024, when it came in at 7.8%. June saw the manufacturing sector post a growth of 7.8%, up from 5.2% in May and 2.4% in the same month last year. As the sector makes up three-fourth of the entire IIP, its performance is the driving force behind the entire industry's growth. According to Aditi Nayar, Chief Economist at ICRA, the rise in manufacturing output was responsible for 199 basis points (bps) of the 235bps rise in overall industrial growth from May.

Within manufacturing, 19 of the 23 industry groups posted higher output on a year-on-year basis in June, up from Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

17 in April and 16 in May, pointed out Megha Arora, Director at India Ratings & Research. This, Arora said, suggested the industrial recovery is “slowly finding its feet and getting generalised”.

Production of electrical equipment continued to rise rapidly, posting a growth of 34% in June. This was followed by ‘motor vehicles, trailers and semi-trailers’, where the output rose 17.5%.

While a low base pushed up manufacturing and overall IIP growth sharply higher in June, it also helped mining growth edge up to 1% from a 1.4% contraction in May. Within ‘mining and quarrying’, metallic minerals including rare earth minerals continued to see very rapid growth, with the output in June estimated to have expanded by 38.9%. However, this was countered by a 13.4% contraction in the output of ‘non-metallic minerals including minor mineral’, which has a higher weight in the IIP.

Output of the ‘electricity and gas supply’ segment jumped 10.6%, primarily due to a 13% rise in electricity generation from non-renewable sources. According to Barclays

• June IIP growth highest since July 2024



Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1 and smallest sector in the IIP and a new addition under the new 2022-23 base year series that was released in May, saw steady expansion of 6.1%.

In terms of the use-based classification of the goods produced, the production of capital goods (up 14.2%) rose the most despite the absence of a favourable base. Intermediate goods' output rose 9.3%, while that of construction goods was 7.5% higher. According to Nayar

Overall electricity generation was 11.4% higher year-on-year in June and 9.3% in April-June on account of the high temperatures and delayed monsoon.

‘Water supply, sewerage & waste management’, the fourth

of ICRA, this suggests investment activity remained robust in June, “benefitting from the easing of tensions in West Asia as well as the large rainfall deficit seen in June that offered extended period for activity”.

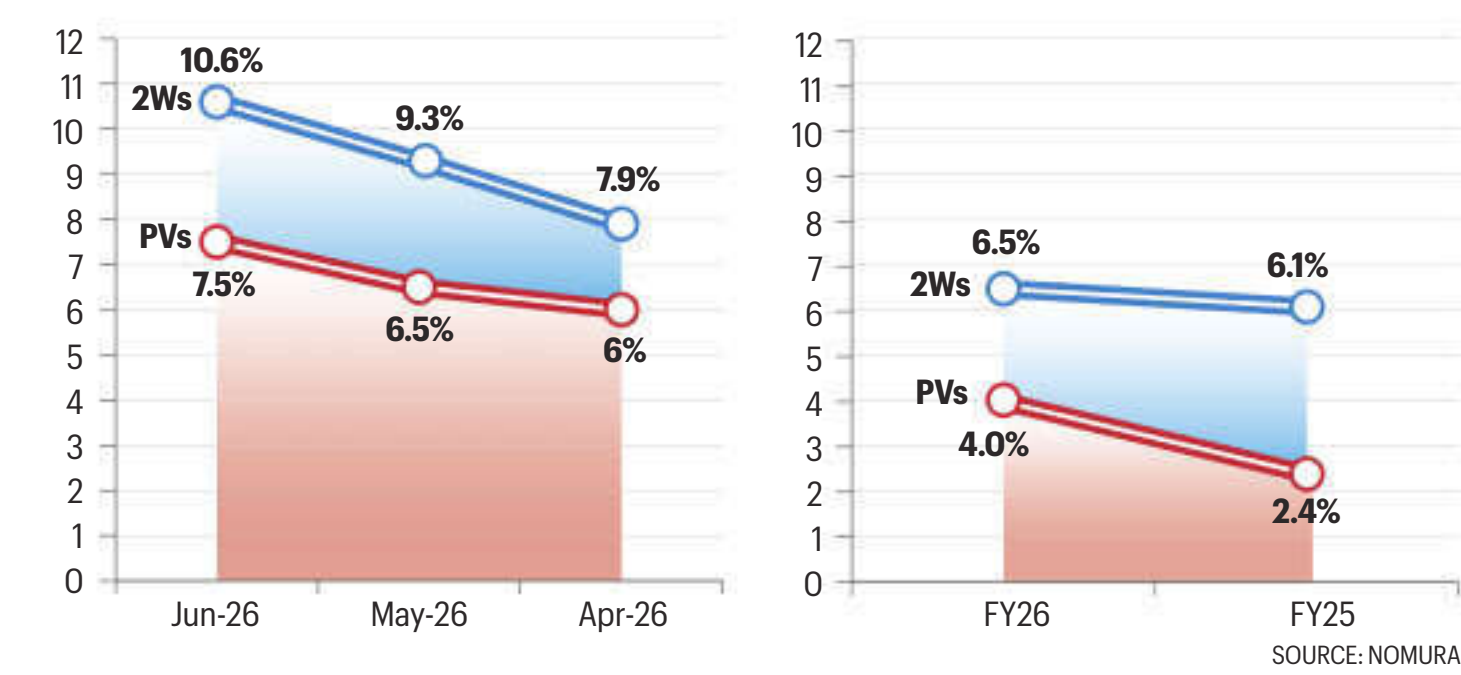
Consumer goods also saw a respectable increase in their output. Durable goods rose 7.7%, broadly steady at May's 8% growth, while production of non-durables rose 4.9% after shrinking by 0.4% the previous month.

However, Vikrant Chaturvedi, Associate Director at Brickwork Ratings, warned the sub-par rains “threatens rural consumption” while also posing upside risks to inflation.

“Furthermore, although active military engagement in the Middle East has paused, persistent regional tensions continue to drive troubling oil price volatility. For corporate credit profiles, these overlapping headwinds signal potential margin compression in the second half of the fiscal year. Sustaining the current industrial trajectory will increasingly depend on domestic investment durability to offset these mounting macroeconomic pressures,” Chaturvedi added.

Alternative-fuel vehicles account for 40% of car sales; EV demand surges

• EV penetration has been rising in both 2-wheelers and 4-wheelers



Akash Mandal
Mumbai, July 28

ELECTRIC VEHICLE (EV) and hybrid purchases have been gaining traction as Indian consumers shift towards alternative-fuel vehicles, amid elevated petrol and diesel prices and mounting inflationary concerns in the wake of the West Asia war.

While overall retail sales for the automobile industry grew by 22% in June, alternative-fuel vehicles — electric, hybrid and compressed natural gas (CNG) vehicles — together accounted for more than 40% of passenger vehicle retail sales for the first time, up from around 38% in May.

CNG accounted for 24.3% of sales, followed by hybrids at 8.3% and EVs at 7.8%, as elevated petrol and diesel prices strengthened the case for lower running costs.

Around 63% of EV sales in June came from the two-wheeler segment, while only around 10% came from four-wheelers, according to Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations data.

Alongside lower fuel costs, EVs also offer higher savings on maintenance and registration

taxes, with many state governments offering concessions on EV registrations.

While hybrids also provide a viable eco-friendly option for customers, they rake up just one-fourth of the sales seen across EVs due to higher taxes and lower government incentives. Currently, a 5% goods and services tax (GST) is levied on EVs, while taxes on hybrids stretch up to 40-48%, similar to internal combustion engine (ICE) vehicles.

Concerns over rising fuel costs are the biggest driver of this sharp growth. Fuel prices at petrol pumps have risen by Rs 7-11 across cities since the West Asia war began in February. While EVs are more expensive than traditional ICE vehicles, reports have shown that they cost significantly less over the ownership period due to fuel savings. Despite the relatively low density of charging stations, consumers are still opting for EVs.

“There is no major issue with the charging infrastructure for now, as these EVs are mostly passenger vehicles that have parking at home where you can charge. And their driving range is not that long. That's why it's

making sense for people to buy EVs over ICE,” said Ravi Gupta, analyst at InCred Capital.

EV penetration rose to 7.5% in the passenger vehicle category in June from 4% as of the end of the January-March quarter, according to Nomura. This rise, just three months into FY27, is already more than the 160-basis-point year-on-year increase seen in FY26.

Tata Motors reported its highest-ever monthly EV sales in June, rising 183% year-on-year to nearly 15,000 units and outpacing the 67% growth seen in the passenger vehicle category. Electric four-wheeler makers such as Tata Motors and Maruti Suzuki have also launched new EV models this year, with more in the pipeline.

“Most of the growth is through two-wheelers, which do not have range issues as they are not used inter-city. The batteries are good enough now for city purposes, lasting 4-5 days. Of course, with more charging stations, we will see EVs become popular in the smaller markets too,” an analyst tracking the sector at a domestic mutual fund said.

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In Apr-Jun, solar output curtailed sharply amid grid constraints

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, July 28

DURING APRIL-June, when the country's peak power demand touched a record high of 270 gigawatts (GW), the grid operators had to curtail 8,133 gigawatt-hour (GWh) of electricity generated by solar power sources due to transmission bottlenecks and to maintain grid security, Ministry of New and Renewable Energy informed the Parliament on Tuesday.

The curtailed electricity from solar sources is approximately equal to one-and-a-half days' worth of power consumed by the entire country in April-June.

Solar power curtailment

stood at 2,417 GWh in April, rose to 3,235 GWh in May and fell to 2,481 GWh in June, the ministry said. “Renewable energy curtailment is implemented for reliable and secure operation of the grid,” it added.

Curtailment — when grid operators ask renewable energy plants to reduce generation to maintain system stability — translates into a substantial loss of clean electricity at a time when India plans to expand renewable energy capacity to meet its clean energy targets of 500 GW by 2030 from the present 288 GW.

The curtailment occurred despite there being few instances of shortages during daytime peak hours, underlin-

ing the crucial role solar power plays in meeting daytime demand and the scale of surplus generation going unused.

The glut of daytime solar generation was also reflected in power markets. During this summer, the spot electricity prices in the country's power exchanges saw sharp volatility. On several days, the spot price of electricity in the real-time market segment on the Indian Energy Exchange — India's biggest power trading bourse — crashed to near-zero levels during daytime in multiple time slots, only to surge to the regulatory ceiling of Rs 10 per unit (kWh) during night-time.

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• ‘THE EXTENT TO WHICH CAPITAL MARKETS AND ECONOMIES HAVE BECOME INTERTWINED WITH AI HAVE CREATED A VULNERABILITY FOR CREDIT’

Fitch cautions against global AI-correction risks

Reuters
London, July 28

THE AI boom and the risk of a correction are emerging as major global credit risks, ratings agency Fitch has warned, adding to growing concerns that soaring tech valuations and unprecedented AI spending may be running ahead of uncertain future returns.

In its third-quarter Global Risk Outlook, Fitch said the credit backdrop remains dominated by two short-term risks: mounting vulnerability to an AI-related market correction and continued uncertainty linked to the US-Iran conflict. The ratings agency echoed

recent warnings from global watchdogs that the AI boom has become increasingly intertwined with economic growth and with capital markets, particularly in the United States, raising the risks of any major selloff.

“The scale of AI investment is such that the exposure of the economy and overall capital market to such a correction is significant,” Fitch said.

The warning, which is the bluntest so far from any major ratings firm, came as Asia's AI-linked stocks tanked again on Tuesday amid the worries about who's paying for the spending boom and evidence of growing competition from China.



The warning, bluntest so far from any major ratings firm, came as Asia's AI-linked stocks tanked again. REUTERS

Fitch's report highlighted that the US S&P 500's cyclically adjusted price-to-earnings ratio has climbed to levels

close to those seen during the late-1990s dotcom boom, while US corporate bond issuance surged 26% in the first

half of 2026, driven largely by AI-related fundraising.

Amazon, Alphabet, Nvidia, Meta, Oracle and SpaceX together issued \$182 billion of investment-grade bonds, while capital expenditure by Alphabet, Amazon, Meta and Microsoft is projected to jump more than 75% this year to \$700 billion, Fitch said.

It estimated that booming IT investment directly added 1.4 percentage points to first-quarter US GDP growth, while rising equity prices have also helped support household spending through a wealth effect. However, uncertainty over future AI revenues, regulation, competition and la-

bour-market disruption could trigger a potentially significant and prolonged market correction, with widespread macroeconomic implications.

“The extent to which capital markets and economies have become intertwined with AI have created a vulnerability for credit,” Fitch said.

Geopolitical risk remains the other major concern, especially with renewed fighting between the US and Iran in recent weeks and a fresh closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

Fitch expects world growth to slow to 2.4% in 2026 and forecasts US inflation will end the year at 3.7%, reflecting the impact of higher energy prices.



DAY 3
results

	Country	G	S	B	Total
1	AUS	29	13	21	63
2	ENG	10	17	12	39
3	CAN	10	8	10	28
4	SCO	7	4	3	14
5	NIG	6	4	0	10
8	IND	2	5	3	10

*TILL 28/07, 11:45 PM

Kushare soars to silver: ‘Had setbacks but believed in myself’

31-year-old clears 2.25 metres with last edition’s bronze medallist Tejaswin Shankar advising him

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, July 28

WHEN HIGH jumper Sarvesh Kushare cleared 2.25 metres after two failed attempts to confirm a silver medal in the men’s high jump, emotions were high at different locations around the world.

Thousands of kilometres away in Devargaon, Nashik, the Kushare family felt a sense of relief, while in Spala, Poland, his coach Jithin Thomas, who couldn’t travel to Glasgow, was overjoyed.

Sarvesh shed a few tears of joy. Sarvesh won the first major medal of his career and upgraded Tejaswin Shankar’s bronze medal in the high jump from the last edition to silver. He failed to clear 2.28m, but he had sealed the second place. Jamaica’s Romaine Beckford also failed to clear the 2.28m mark but won the gold medal based on the countback.

“We couldn’t eat properly today. Once the event started, all of us were hoping that he stays till the end,” his father Anil Kushare told *The Indian Express*. “When he missed the first jump at 2.25m, his mother started praying and I was restless. But then, he cleared it in the third attempt and we all breathed easily,” Anil said.

Usually calm, Sarvesh broke down while talking to the media later. That is how much this medal meant to him.

“That moment meant a lot to me because it was the result of months of hard work. I had setbacks but believed in myself. When I cleared 2.25m, all those emotions came out at once. I wasn’t thinking about the result, just relieved, happy, and grateful that all the effort had finally paid off. It’s a moment I’ll always remember,”



Sarvesh Kushare won his first multi-sport event medal on Tuesday when he picked up a silver at the Commonwealth Games. PTI



Tejaswin Shankar discussing the high jump event with Sarvesh Kushare in Glasgow on Tuesday. SCRENGRAB

Sarvesh told *The Indian Express* from Glasgow. Sarvesh has been performing admirably since last year, including a top 6 finish at 2025 World Championships, setting a national record last month at the age of 31.

“He has never won a multi-sporting event medal before. Winning at the Common-

“I had setbacks but believed in myself. When I cleared 2.25m, all those emotions came out at once. I wasn’t thinking about the result, just relieved, happy, and grateful that all the effort had finally paid off.”

SARVESH KUSHARE
ON WINNING THE CWG SILVER

wealth Games is like validation for everything that he has done right in the last four years. He was more emotional because it’s a once-in-a-four-year chance,” his coach Jithin said.

Meanwhile, his family in Nashik got emotional looking at Sarvesh crying. “I can understand the tears. He is a

calm guy usually, but those tears were a reflection of our dreams being fulfilled,” his father Anil said.

Team work

Sarvesh arrived in Glasgow as medal favourite and had compatriots Tejaswin Shankar and Aadarsh Ram to compete alongside. Though high jump is an individual event, Sarvesh’s final in Glasgow felt like a team effort.

Tejaswin, who retired because of Acute Patellar Tendinitis, stayed near the high jump pit, advising both Sarvesh and Aadarsh throughout the competition. Coach Jithin, who couldn’t travel to Glasgow, said the presence of Tejaswin was a boost for Sarvesh. “I wasn’t there, but Tejaswin’s constant presence and his advice really helped Sarvesh. I think it just showed how much both of these guys value each other,” Jithin said.

After every jump, Sarvesh would trudge back to the

player’s bench where Tejaswin was sitting to dissect every jump with him.

After the two failures at 2.25m, Tejaswin suggested to Sarvesh to skip and try 2.28m. “I told him that you can go to 2.28m now but Sarvesh said that if I clear 2.25m, then I get three more chances at 2.28m. So, he took that call and delivered. It was a surreal experience to witness the moment so close,” Tejaswin later told NNIS Sports. For Sarvesh, having Tejaswin by side meant that he had someone who he trusts.

“Tejaswin and I have a great friendship, and having someone you trust beside you during such an important competition gives you confidence,” he said. “We always push each other to perform better, and his support throughout the competition meant a lot. Moments like these are even more special when you can share them with a close friend and teammate.”

Ajaya glad to emulate dad’s CWG medal, but still hungry for gold



Ajaya Babu (L) won the silver medal at the Commonwealth Games on Tuesday. His father had won bronze at the 2010 New Delhi edition. PTI

Tanishq Vaddi
Hyderabad, July 28

SIXTEEN YEARS back, Valluri Srinivasa Rao had bagged a men’s 56kg bronze medal at the Delhi Commonwealth Games (CWG). By striking silver in Glasgow, Rao’s son Ajaya Babu has again put Vizianagaram district’s Kondavelagada village on the weightlifting map.

Ajaya lifted a total of 330kg (149kg snatch + 181kg clean and jerk) in the 79kg category, falling one kilogram short of Malaysia’s Erry Hidayat Muhammad. Rao was happy with his son’s feat but Ajaya, while sharing his father’s enthusiasm, kept repeating in his conversation with *The Indian Express*, “If I did not make a few mistakes, I could have won gold.”

Right from the qualification rounds earlier this year, Rao was confident that Ajaya would deliver a medal based on how well he was performing. “I wanted him to go into badminton,” laughed Rao. “Pullela Gopichand and I met during an event where he asked me, ‘What do you think of your son taking up badminton?’ but Ajaya was resolute; he wanted to take up weightlifting.”

The 21-year-old has had his reasons. He was determined to keep the weightlifting tradition intact in his family and the village. “I was about six years old when I was watching my father win a medal on TV in Kondavelagada. I did not understand everything then, but I saw neighbours coming to our home to congratulate him; the media started coming, and they showed my father being congratulated by the chief minister of the state. Our financial status improved significantly after that win,” said Ajaya.

The young boy slowly gravitated towards weightlifting. Then came CWG 2014 in Glasgow. Rao wanted to better his bronze and go for gold. However, destiny had different plans as Rao could not even qualify.

“He was heartbroken for the longest time. He felt he had incomplete business because he couldn’t qualify, and at that moment I took it upon myself to fulfil my father’s desire,” said Ajaya.

Revival of legacy

Once Ajaya decided to take up weightlifting, Rao was “proud,” and slowly started mentoring his son. “It became a dining table conversation. At breakfast, lunch and dinner, all we did was discuss improving

his game, preparations for different tournaments and how to approach things.”

“There were some competitions which I missed in my career for some reason or the other, but I wanted Ajaya to participate in them to get exposure,” Rao added.

In addition to continuing his father’s legacy, picking weightlifting brought challenges. The region’s older guard, who had won national and international medals, began to fade. This required the new generation to start delivering medals to re-establish their pride and continue to keep the next generation of weightlifters hungry, and Ajaya was quite aware of this.

“Usually I am quite confident, someone who does not take a lot of pressure... my father never said I should win medals, but only recently, before CWG, my uncle started emphasising a little more about my father’s legacy and why my winning a medal is a matter of pride. That’s when I got a bit fired up,” Ajaya said.

However, Rao prefers the cool and composed version of Ajaya. “Technically, he is stronger than me, quicker than me, but his ability to be composed under pressure is too good. When I played, I used to get tense,” he said. “I always drilled in him during our meal conversations: you might have a stronger or bigger opponent, but if you trust your practice, you will always win, and that mindset keeps him cool,” said Rao.

Wary of doping

“Even today, whether he is in Glasgow, Patiala or Kondavelagada, I meticulously ask about all the technical aspects of his game, what sort of training he did, whether he sustained any injuries, and what food he is having,” Rao said. Although the basics of weightlifting ingrained by Rao played their part, the 21-year-old said the actual game-changer was the supplements his father suggested. “I am very particular when it comes to even the water that Ajaya drinks. I have seen through my playing career how easily players test positive for doping... I have seen this happen in the careers of many athletes; sometimes, bad people with ill-intent who dislike a particular weightlifter mix a banned substance in their water, cold drink or food without their knowledge, spoiling a career as a result. I wanted to be extremely careful of such things with Ajaya,” said Rao.